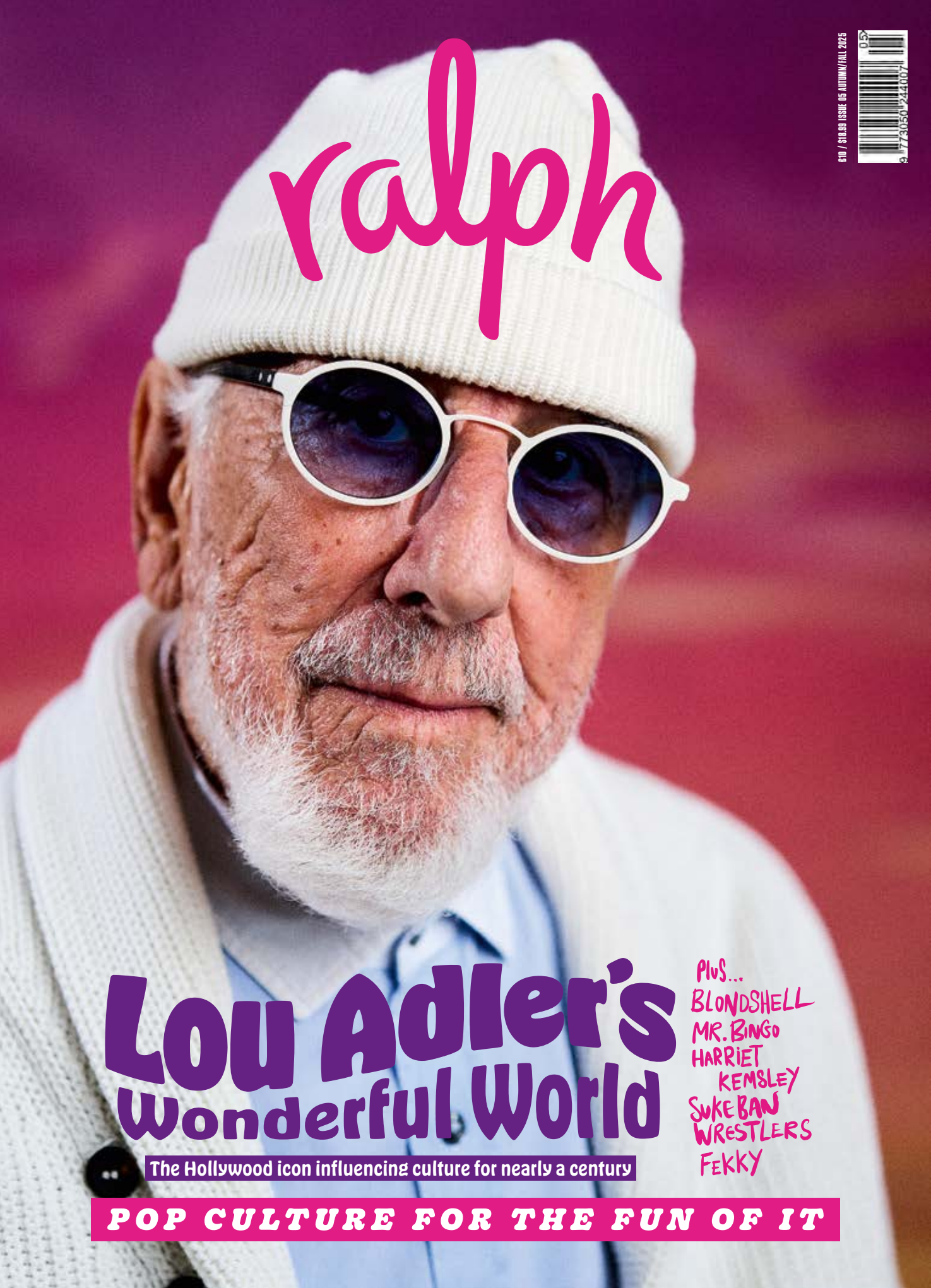




ralph

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Lou Adler's Wonderful World

The Hollywood icon influencing culture for nearly a century

Plus...
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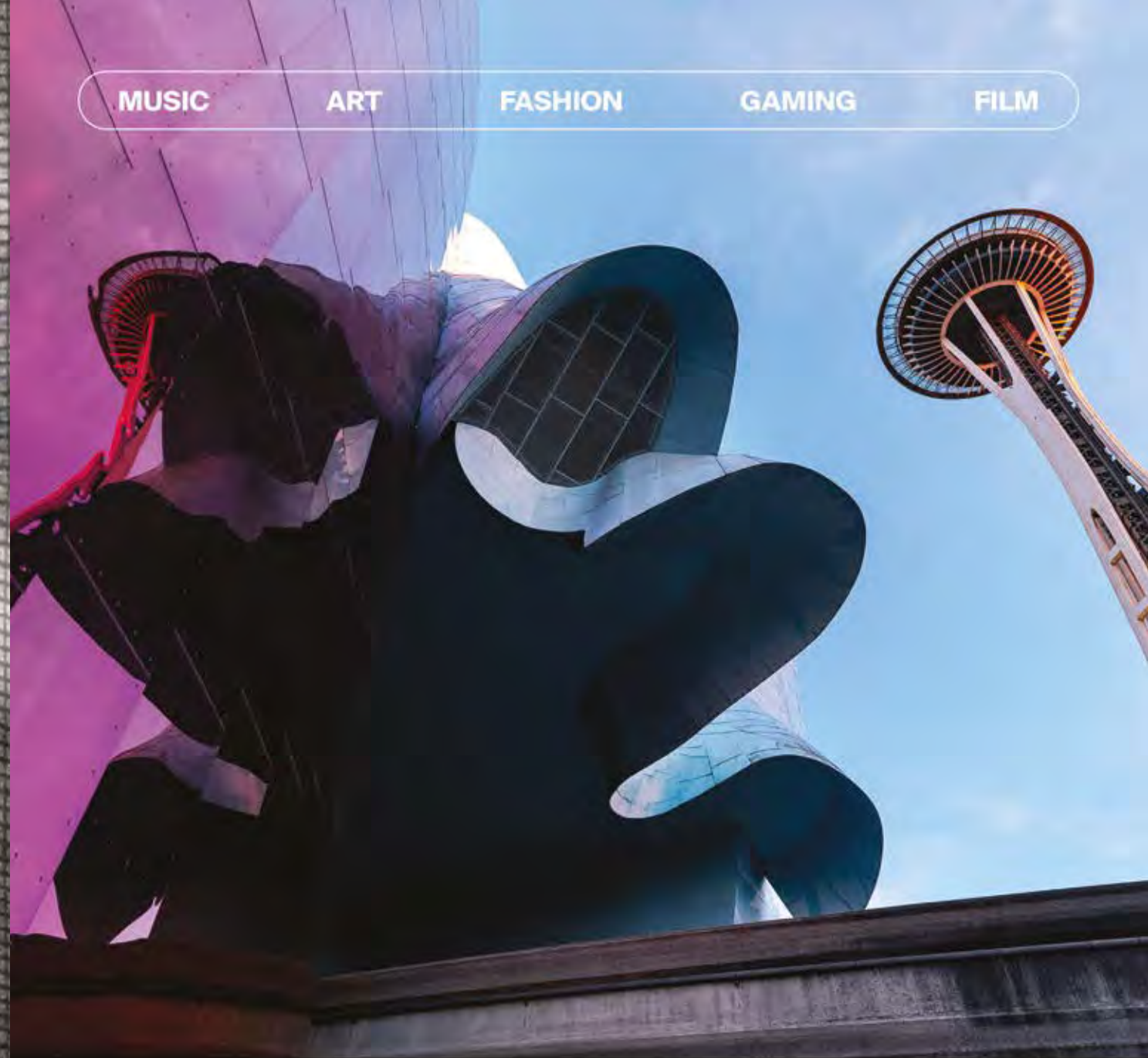
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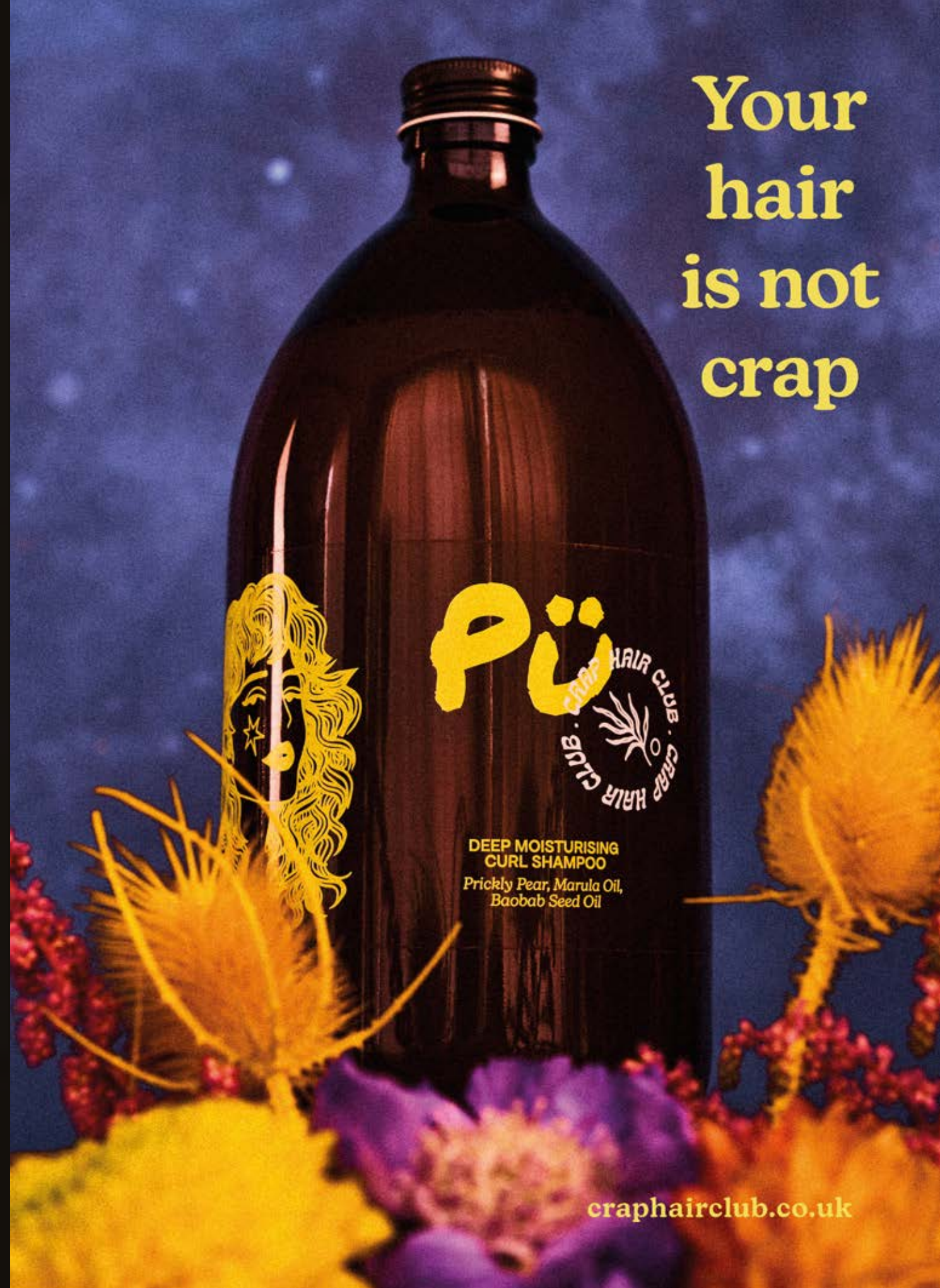
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Editor's Letter

Well I never – it's *Ralph* 05. We're storming through 2025.

And what an honour it is to have a true pop culture icon on the cover of this issue.

Hollywood hitmaker Lou Adler has influenced us through song and screen for nearly a century, working with the likes of Sam Cook, The Mamas & the Papas, Carole King and Neil Young. He also bought *The Rocky Horror Picture Show* to the big screen (after seeing the small scale play with then girlfriend Britt Eckland), discovered stoner comedy icons Cheech & Chong, and opened the Roxy on Sunset Strip with best mate Jack Nicholson. His glitzy stories might be incredible, but Lou, at 91 years old, has remained humble, loves to have fun and holds his family as the most important thing to him. What a guy.

On top of that, we ask American rock sensation Blondshell her views on goths and tacos, go backstage with brilliant play *How To Win Against History*, have exclusive behind the scenes pics of the set building of Ben Wheatley's mind-twisting new film *BULK*, go to the park with comedian Harriet Kemsley, wrestle in LA with the iconic Japanese female Sukeban wrestlers, do a deep dive on the music scene at Calgary's Stampede festival, and loads more.

To paraphrase one of Lou Adler's songs, What A Wonderful World that all this stuff exists.

Enjoy

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BLOND nos HELL

BLONDOS HELL



BLONDOSHELL

Words by Josh Jones
Photos by Daniel Topete

Since signing to Partisan Records and setting the indie rock world alight with her 2023 eponymous debut album, life for Blondshell (aka New Yorker Sabrina Mae Teitelbaum), has been pure rock 'n' roll. So what do you ask a bonafide rockstar who's been travelling the world playing massive shows, performing on TV, and comfortably lining up alongside the likes of Queens of the Stone Age, Kneecap, Amyl & The Sniffers and Fontaines D.C.? Well, as she's already been asked a LOT about her sophomore album *If You Asked For a Picture*, you ask important questions about synths, dinosaurs and tacos...

What's your favourite pre-programmed rhythm on a synthesizer? I always went for Bossa Nova, if you're interested.

I'm a no rhythm girl. Maybe just the natural beat of a heart. It's free time ballads only.

What's the best computer game soundtrack (GTA radio isn't allowed)?

If *Guitar Hero* counts, then the one with 'Snow (Hey Oh)' by Red Hot Chili Peppers.

If *If You Asked For A Picture* was a dinosaur, which one would it be?

Triceratops because they're stocky and feisty.

Which tracks on the record took the quickest and longest to write and record?

Hmmm. Quickest was probably 'Toy'. I wrote that song on tour and I only had a fixed amount of time to do it before a show. Longest was probably 'T&A' because we ended up mixing up verses and choruses at the last minute.

What's best to write a song with - pen and paper or phone and voice notes?

For me, phone and voice notes all the way. I sometimes use a computer for lyrics, because the bigger screen is nice and the light on the phone goes off while you're playing guitar.



“I’ve had many memorable tacos and I do think they’re accurately rated”

With TV appearances, festivals, tours and being on line ups with bands like Amyl & The Sniffers, Queens of The Stone Age, Fontaines DC and Kneecap, do you put “rockstar” in your occupation when you fill in a form?
Definitely. Beautiful and intelligent as well.

Who would you rather survive the apocalypse and repopulate the earth - Goths or Skate Punks?
Goths for sure. I would adapt and become one. Also the clothes would be better.

After Blondshell - what’s the best shell?
Two Shell.

Top 5 airports?
I actually hate airports so I’ll actually give you my top 5 worst airports:
1. Denver
2. Newark
3. SeaTac
4. Charlotte. NC
5. The main Atlanta one that everyone goes to

Tacos are extremely overrated. Discuss.
I completely disagree! I’ve had many memorable tacos and I do think they’re accurately rated. Please come to LA or go to Mexico City. *ralph*



Blondshell's *If You Asked For a Picture* is out now on Partisan Records



Harriet Kemsley Will NEVER Divorce a Comedian Again

Our Comedy Editor talks dating, jokes in bed,
and trying not to laugh in front of Bob Mortimer
with the soon-to-be national treasure

Words by Alexandra Haddow
Photos by Stephanie Sian Smith

Harriet Kemsley has one of those faces that's always smiling even when she's not. She's a beacon of fun, silliness and positivity on the comedy circuit, but you might know her as someone trying not to laugh at all costs. She's been gathering fans for years with her stand-up, podcasts and appearances on various TV shows such as Would I Lie To You, Cats Does Countdown, but I had a lot of 'Do you know Harriet Kemsley?!' when she appeared on Amazon's surprise hit Last One Laughing earlier this year. The answer is yes I do, I've gigged and podcasted with her several times over the years, and she always brings her own unique flavour of genius and chaos to anything she does. If you haven't seen it, Last One Laughing is the gameshow where professional comics (including The World's Best Man™, Bob Mortimer) try to make each other laugh, doing increasingly outrageous bits, and if they crumble? They're out. It shouldn't work but it does, and Kemsley is undoubtedly the star of the show, looking so helpless trying hard not to crease into laughter.

Watching her in anything, whether it's her show Bobby and Harriet get Married on Vice TV, which documented the lead up to her wedding to fellow comedian Bobby Mair (the couple have recently separated), the many TV appearances, or one of her stand-up shows, you get the feeling there's absolutely no boundary between stage Harriet and real Harriet. She's a performer willing to try most things, as evidenced at this year's Edinburgh Fringe where she performed a show from a hotel bed. Kemsley has that

incredible ability to seem like your best friend whatever she does, so it's no wonder her legion of fans is growing fast. I caught up with her as soon she definitely won't have time...

Alex: I feel like you're really open and confessional with everything you do. It doesn't feel like there's a barrier between real you and you on stage. Is that on purpose?

Harriet: I was very shy when I was younger and so it's a way of connecting. It's like the more I've done it, the more I've been able to feel like I can be myself quicker. I think you probably feel the same, like, 'Oh my god why did I say that?' The more I can share things the more it kind of gets rid of this shame of the things I talk about. I had a lot of shame when I was younger and I was on my own with it. The more I perform comedy, the more I'm conscious of not saying particular things about people in my life – I'm very happy to make fun of myself but then you start to get a bit panicked about other people.

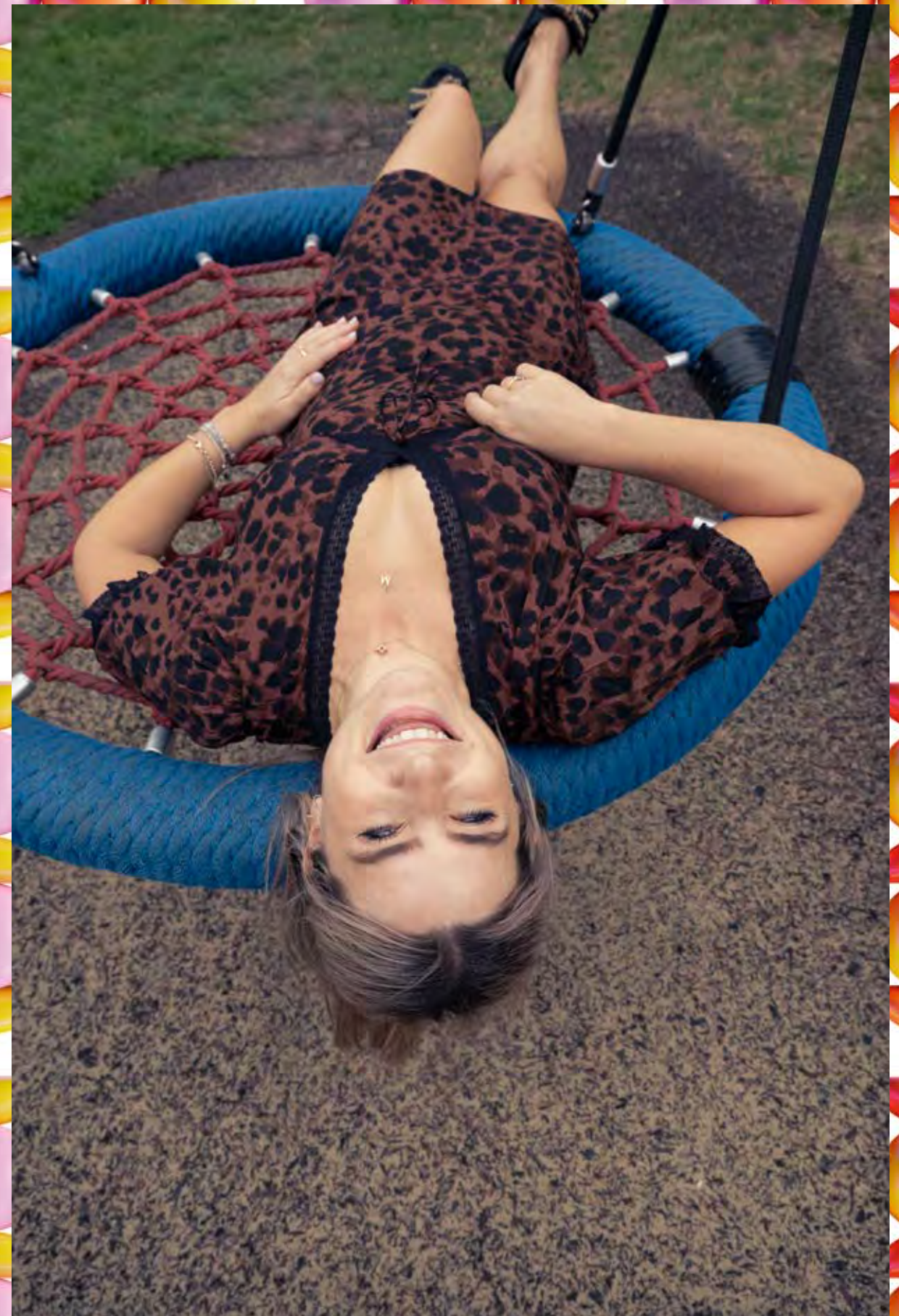
Alex: I feel as I write more that maybe I should be disguising things. I was single for a long time when I was starting to do shows, and now I've got a boyfriend and I'm saying things about him on stage. Then people having a drink with him after are thinking, "Well, I know about your penis now, so that's nice."

Harriet: (Laughing) Is he OK with it?

Alex: He's fine with it. He's a musician, which isn't the same thing, but he gets it.

Harriet: I'm going to have to find somebody that's really comfortable with that. I can't imagine somebody that I love and I'm going to partner with saying, "Oh no, you can't talk about me" – that they wouldn't have a sense of humour about themselves.

Alex: Yeah exactly, I've actually never had anyone say anything like that yet and I don't





know if that's indicative of who we surround ourselves with...

Harriet: Well, this is it! As I start to date people, maybe in the real world it might be a problem, my perception is skewed of how people think. The thing with comedians is they – particularly male comics – love it when you point out a flaw because it's like a new aspect that they can explore. They love it in this weird fucked up way.

Alex: Definitely! At the Fringe this year, you were doing something completely different. I was really gutted that I wasn't there because especially for this interview, I really wanted to see it/be involved with it.

Harriet: I was really nervous about it!

Alex: Tell us the concept.

Harriet: So, Hotel Indigo had this mad idea where I do a show in a hotel bedroom – it didn't feel too crazy because I don't know if you remember, but Leicester Comedy Festival used to do a show where you'd go between hotel rooms? [I've never heard of it] So I'd kind of done something similar before. But what I didn't realise was that I'd be doing the show in bed with 18 chairs in front of me. A woman came in her pyjamas all the way from Fife to watch.

Alex: No!

Harriet: Yeah! I didn't actually sleep in the room, I was secretly staying in the room two doors down. So I did it in my pyjamas. I walked in, got into bed and did this show for 30 minutes. Then went back to my room. Everyone at the beginning of the Fringe was like, "what is wrong with you? How do you get yourself in this situation?" But by the end, people thought I'd nailed it. I was just performing from bed.

Alex: Honestly, when I heard about it, I thought, she's won. She's actually gone and

beaten the system'.

Harriet: It did get quite hot under the duvet.

Alex: Did you have a mic?

Harriet: No, I realised it could have been excruciating, but actually it was just so silly – as the audience walked in we were all just laughing. Even though it was through the hotel, it felt very 'Fringe-y', so I chatted to the audience and did a bit of material off the back of the chat to try and keep it natural. It was bizarre, but fun.

Alex: Did it feel a bit like being at your own wake?

Harriet: A little bit. It was a bit like I was on my deathbed. The day I was supposed to go home I got trapped by a storm! The hotel were so nice and let me stay, but the only room available was the room that I'd done the show in. Then I was so worried I was going to have a nightmare and wake up with 15 people sitting and watching me.

Alex: Do you think you'll do something different in future as well now?

Harriet: Yeah, maybe. It felt really fun. Stressful before I did it. Then it was a bit like, 'why aren't we all kind of doing something a little bit different?' But also there is something so comforting about just being on stage with a microphone. [laughing] So maybe not.

Alex: When I read about it, the main thing I was thinking was I feel like I would have to hold something, anything in place of a mic.

Harriet: That's what I was thinking. It just feels so weird. It felt like a sleepover or something. It was just like gossiping. The first time I walked in, the curtains were open. I had to shut them, otherwise the double decker bus was going to be looking in.

Alex: People on the bus thinking, 'that lady off the TV is in bed! She's hosting some kind of orgy or something.' Speaking of TV, I also wanted to ask you about *Last One Laughing*. When I heard the concept before I watched it I thought 'this is not going to work.' Then I watched it and loved it. When you were approached about it, did you think that too or did you know it would be a hit?

Harriet: When I watched the Canadian version beforehand, I really loved that there were a few moments where the comics could just be silly and be themselves. But it definitely felt scary going in, because the bar was so high with the other comics. I felt like in *Celebrity Big Brother* when they had Chantelle pretending that she was a celebrity? Like I was pretending that I was on Bob Mortimer's level. I felt like a fraud! But everyone was so good-natured and constantly on the verge of laughter. It could've felt mean, but because everyone was a bit hysterical it was really fun and silly, and childish.

Alex: I mean it is basically *Big Brother* for comedians right? Even the setup and the way you're walking around it felt really 'Big Brothery'.

Harriet: I know, that's why it felt so weird – that there were no cameramen in there. I think it's so lovely that they just completely trusted the comics.

Alex: How long were you in there for?

Harriet: A really long time! You can see in the last couple of hours that we're losing our minds a bit. I didn't know how to function without laughing. So much of my life is laughing at myself and laughing at other people.

Alex: It's the punctuation of how we communicate isn't it? What was it like having to do a striptease for *The Best Man On Earth™*, Bob Mortimer?

Harriet: I don't know if you can see in my face, I'm in another place. I'm somewhere else. That's how I tried to do it.

Alex: I also want to talk about your amazing podcast, *Single Ladies in Your Area*. How did it come about?

Harriet: Myself and Amy [Gledhill, fellow comedian] were backstage at a gig together, and had both come out of really long-term relationships so we'd never done the dating apps or anything. It felt so daunting and then we were chatting about it with our agent and we said "Oh we should do a podcast!" Because this is the stuff we want to know. We didn't know how to join the apps, or how to date people in this way. We'd just fallen into relationships with people that we probably shouldn't have. So to consciously get advice on what to do and how to break our patterns, we thought it would be fun! We'd both had big break ups. I was a little bit further ahead, but I also had been basically completely celibate for ages. It felt so scary.

Alex: I think the reason it's become popular is because although there are a lot of dating podcasts, there aren't in this way – where you, the hosts, are the novices.

Harriet: What I realised is there are a lot of dating podcasts with very confident people talking about dating. Our first series, thinking about it now, is so pathetic. We go on one date between us over 20 episodes and the whole thing is meant to be about dating. But I think that's why people relate to it because dating is so hard. The apps are hard, being in your 30s and dating when everyone's settled down, is so hard. So I think because we're having such a hard time, it feels very relatable.

Alex: You're saying "Help us!"

Harriet: Yeah! We're learning the audience are also learning. Fellow stand-up Stephen Bailey was very good as a guest, because so

"So much of my life is laughing at myself"



“Stand-up is such a lifetime’s work. You’re always trying to get better”



many of our friends come on and say, “you girls are doing so well!” But Stephen was like “you girls are useless!” Amy had a picture on her profile that looked like it was taken in a graveyard, I think it might actually have been taken in a graveyard. I think Stephen had the best advice, which was to stop dating comedians.

Alex: You guys both dated comedians before, I’m guessing you’ve dated non-comedians since. What do you think is the biggest difference?

Harriet: With comics there’s a shorthand, there’s a language isn’t there? Where you just feel comfortable. I think I definitely become a bit more formal on dates with real people because I thought that’s what they’re going to expect. And to be honest, it probably is. But I haven’t dated – properly become boyfriend/girlfriend with – anyone that isn’t a comic since before I did stand up. So it is going to be an interesting thing. But I’ve just been trying to go on dates with people where I find their jobs interesting. I love what I do and it’s a huge part of my life, so I want a partner that also has a passion. It doesn’t even have to be their job, but something that they’re really interested in and are very passionate about.

Alex: We do live a slightly abnormal life, but I think it’s a really sweeping statement where people say “I would never date a comic” and you’re like, “We are people as well!”

Harriet: I cannot divorce another comedian though, that’s something I’ve got to stop doing [laughing].

Alex: That’s the headline! How did you guys pitch *Bobby & Harriet Get Married*? Did you

get engaged and decide it would be funny if you did a kind of pseudo reality show about it?

Harriet: Yeah, it was crazy. We got commissioned to do it about six weeks before we actually got married. So we were writing and filming. It was one of the maddest times of my life. The chaos that was happening behind the scenes. It could have been a real HBO drama or something. We filmed on our actual wedding day but, because we were in control of it, it was only little moments here and there. That’s one of the things I’m most proud of. I loved doing it so much. And the way that we did it, which was loosely scripted, but improvisational.

Alex: What’s next?

Harriet: I’m going to write a new stand-up show that I’m going to tour next year, which I’m really excited for. My last show I loved, but it was written at a certain time in my life and I feel like I’m not there anymore. Stand-up is such a lifetime’s work. You’re always trying to get better and you’re always trying to become more and more yourself, so that’s the next thing. I’d love to do something scripted, something like *Bobby & Harriet Get Married*. That would be my dream, so trying to pitch lots of things and trying to manifest it to the universe.

Alex: *Bobby and Harriet Don’t Get Married?*

Harriet: *Harriet Gets Married Again.*

Alex: *Harriet Kemsley Does Not Divorce Another Comedian.*

Harriet: That’s the show! That’s the show for sure. *ralph*

THE TALENTED m bingo

Talking shop with the very sociable artist

Words by Josh Jones
Photos by Dan Wilton
Painting by Nelly Randall



The shop door doesn't do a cheery tinkly jingle when I open it. "It should," I tell the shop keeper. He smiles and agrees. We sit down at a tiny round table. For sale in this shop are a baseball bat, gravestones, beermats, plates, cards, jigsaws, tea towels and many, many pieces of art. This shop owner doesn't take things seriously at all.

It all belongs to the artist Mr Bingo, and this shop is his latest project. "I'm a very friendly person," he says relaxing into a chair [full disclosure, I've known him since Ralph's Art Director James-Lee Duffy introduced us about 20 years ago, so we just got straight into things] "I'm much more sociable than most artists, who like to hide away and make work, which is fine. Occasionally they're forced to be interviewed or go out in front of people in a gallery space. If they're a successful artist they have people to do all that stuff for them." But Bingo actually likes all that stuff, and he really likes meeting people (especially if they buy his work). Before the Mr Bingo shop idea was born, he would host several open studio days per year, welcoming fans to come and see where he worked. "People always really enjoyed it," he says. "And I was like, 'This is great, but I don't want to just do this four days a year. I want to do this all the time.'"

So, for the uninformed, as there have been several iterations of him, the Mr Bingo story has gone a bit like this:

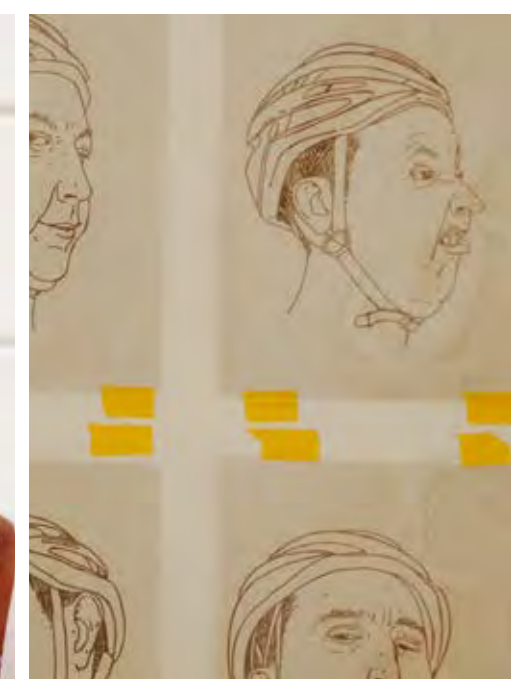
There was the *Successful Commercial Artist Bingo*, who illustrated for the likes of *The Mighty Boosh* and New York Times, MTV, Channel 4 and more. That's the Bingo that decided to forsake all commercial commissions and concentrate on his art. This is where his droll observations on life began to grow a global following. Much has been written about this Bingo, so we don't really need to touch on it here.

Then there was *Hate Mail* Kickstarter Bingo – where he wrote and starred in a rap video to get his Kickstarter noticed. He was looking to publish a book of his *Hate Mail* project where he'd send people insulting and hilarious illustrations on postcards (they asked, and paid, for this service). This saw his worldwide fandom explode. And this has really been written about a lot. Like really loads. And that's not why this feature's in *Ralph*.

Then there was *Walking Bingo*, who took a year off to explore the world, mainly hiking along coastland paths. "I didn't come back feeling like a new person. I went when I was 44 so I kind of already knew who I was," he laughs. "People thought I was going to come back with dreadlocks and tattoos. I came back exactly the same, just way more grateful. Before I left, I thought hadn't really done that much with my life. But, by thinking about it for a year, and seeing the shock on the faces of strangers I met – many of whom were old, retired people – when I described what I did, it made me think that actually, maybe I am interesting and that I have done something with my life. And I could be proud of what I've done. It was some kind of validation." Not much has been written about this era, because he was on a massive holiday.

So here we are – the latest Bingo: *Mr Bingo the Shopkeeper*.

Just shy of a 20-minute walk from London's Kings Cross station, you'll find his eponymously-named shop. Situated on the wide (for London) boulevard that is Amwell Street, his somewhat understated shop front features just his signature above the window and a bass drum with a lady showing her bum drawn on it. It seems so well-bedded in among the coffee shops, pub and independent stores, you'd have thought he'd been here for years. But he actually only opened it in September 2024. And it's only open when he wants it to be.



“As soon
as you open
the door, it’s
a different
space...
people just
wander in and
and start a
conversation”



“One of the things I love most about my job is I don’t ever have to have meetings”



Inside, the shop is small, clean and, as you’d imagine, full of all the things I mentioned at the beginning of this feature. All of it artwork by Mr Bingo. All of it for sale. Everything is washed in his signature it’s-funny-cos-it’s-true sense of humour – living in that grey area of not really offensive but you know someone will find it offensive. The gravestones are inscribed with a simple ‘Don’t Forget To Have Fun’ and the beer mats have a picture of a cigarette in an ashtray and proclaim ‘BORED OF WELLNESS’. Both of these tickled the iconic David Hockney so much, that he bought two gravestones and a whole load of beer mats, among other things.

So is the shop just a natural next step from his open studios, I ask. “I had this idea of instead of getting a studio, just renting a shop and using it as a studio, and then opening it whenever I feel like it as an ongoing experiment,” he says. So, in the world according to Bingo, the shop might open for one day a week, or it might open seven days a week. Or not at all – opening hours are entirely down to how he feels.

But to Mr Bingo, having a door on a street changes everything, because it means, whenever the feeling takes him, he can be open. Just like that. “As soon as you open the door, it’s a different space,” he explains. “Sometimes people wander past and just look in. If they look interested enough or friendly, I’ll just let them in, and then they sometimes buy something. I think that’s really amazing. You’ve made a sale, and turned the space into a shop just for five minutes. And you’ve met someone brand new. I’ve had studios for 20 years where you lock yourself into your little box, do you work and go out. In this shop, if it’s a hot day and I decide to have the door open, people will wander in and start a conversation. At first I was really confused why people were walking into my office. Then I realised it’s because it looks like a shop. Because it IS a shop!”

The shop has become a handy focal point for Mr Bingo fans. Now they can drop in and

meet their favourite artist most weeks. Just a cursory look at his Instagram stories (he usually takes a picture of anyone who visits) will show visitors from Australia, most of Europe, North and South America, Japan, India and beyond. The shop has become an IRL clubhouse for his online community as well as a solid part of the actual Amwell Street community. “I find it really nice that when my fans visit, they all actually chat to each other,” Bingo chuckles. “You don’t really get customers talking to anyone in most shops. It really does feel like they’re part of a weird cult. The local area is a really nice, old fashioned bit of London. People have lived here for years and they seem like they’re intrigued and amused by this new shop on the street that has a bass drum sitting in the window with a woman’s arse drawn on it. The other shopkeepers on the street like it. I think it’s such a lovely thing when local people walk past and look in.”

Recently, Bingo wondered if he could put on a talk. Part of the magic of having your own shop is that there’s no one to answer to. “It’s just me trying to use the space really. I like making things up as I go along. I’ve never been someone to sit down and have a five-year plan. One day, I thought it would be fun to do a talk in here, so I put tickets up online and they sold out the same day. So then I knew 30 people would be in my shop two weeks later. Then I knew I needed to buy a TV to show slides on and some benches. So that’s what I did.”

It sounds simple... because it is. There are no management or publicists getting involved. “I love that style of working when you just do everything on the fly,” he laughs. “One of the things I love most about my job is I don’t ever have to have meetings. Sometimes I get things wrong and with hindsight, having a meeting with at least one other person might have made things better, but at least I don’t have to have meetings.”

“The main good thing is that David Hockney bought some of the my work”

I wanted to pick up on something he said earlier about his fans being part of a “weird cult”. Does he consider himself a cult artist? Many people would label him as such. “I think you might have to be dead to be a cult artist,” he says. “I’m very good at shouting about anything slightly good that happens to me. I don’t keep anything a secret.” But David Hockney buying your work and saying nice things about you must be an ego boost, I say. Surely that adds to the myth of being a cult artist? “I got this order for 20 of my beer mats, which is weird as most people buy just one or two,” Bingo explains. “So I Googled the person that bought them and it said they worked for David Hockney. I thought that was incredible – so I emailed them and asked if I could put it on my socials. It’s unusual that I even asked, normally I’ll just put anything on there. But it’s David Hockney and you’re so respectful of him. His assistant went and asked and came back with an actual quote for me. And that’s just a PR dream isn’t it? Getting a free quote from a really respected, famous person about the art you’ve made. So I wrote it down and posted a picture of it. And it became news, which was mental. *The Guardian* wrote a piece about it and then a load of other papers copied them. It was all so good for me. But the main good thing was that David Hockney bought some of my work.”

I’ve known Mr Bingo for a good amount of time and I don’t think I can overstate how successful his *Hate Mail* campaign was. It became all-consuming, and he became globally famous. There’s success and there’s happiness and often they don’t go hand in hand. Bingo the shopkeeper seems more zen, more laid back I tell him. So, I have to ask, is... is he happy?

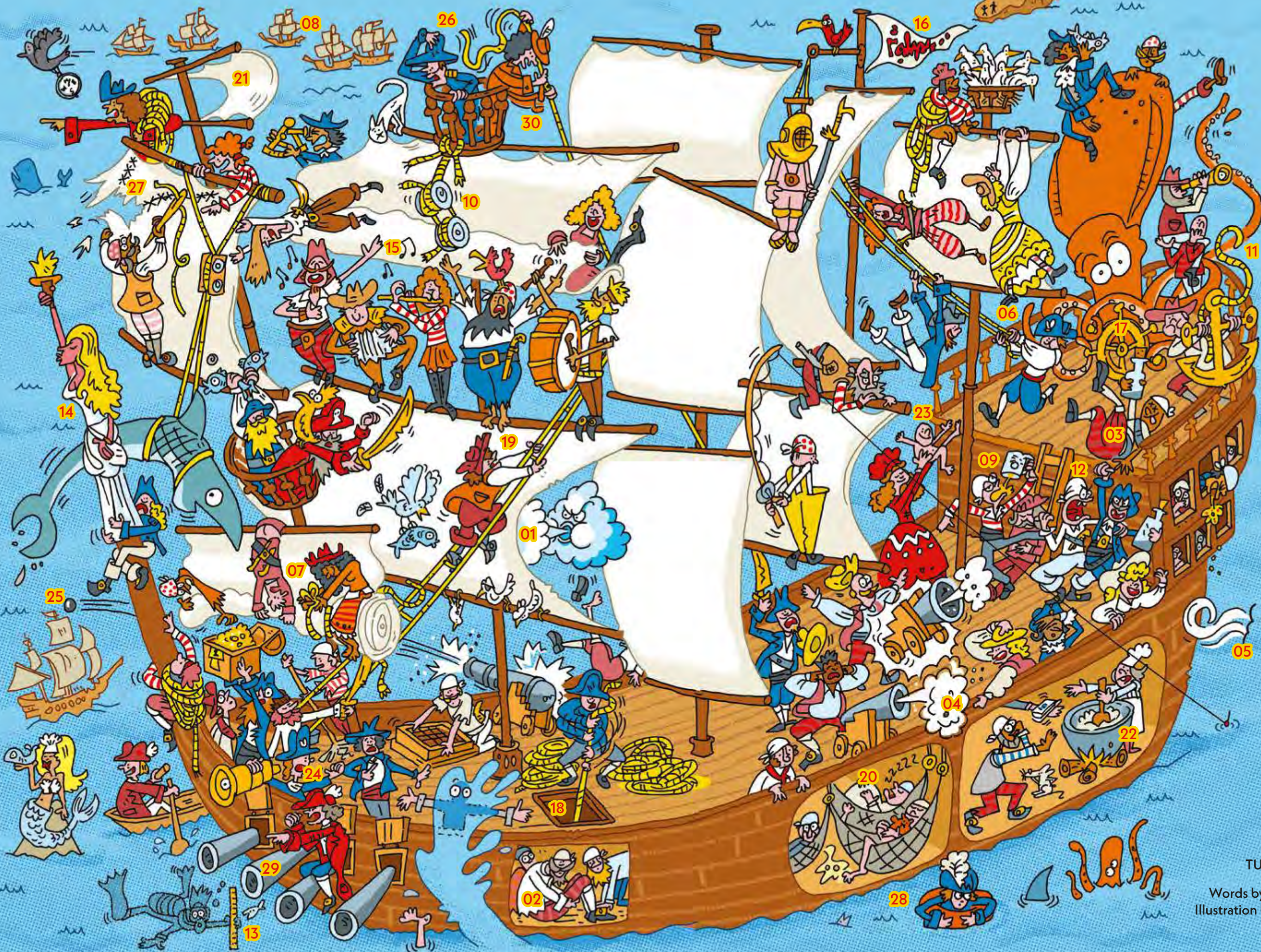
“Am I happy?” he replies, eyebrows arched. “Yes. Right now I’m happy. I’d say I’m probably an 8.5/10. It’s pretty high, I’m not happy all the time but I’m very happy at the moment. The shop’s a happy place. Would I be as happy if I didn’t have it? I don’t think I would be – it grounds me having work to do, having an audience that are really keen on me making new stuff all the time and having a physical space to nurture. All of that stuff gives me a lot in life. I live on my own and I work on my own, so if I didn’t have this space then my life would be very solitary. I think we all need something in life to look after and nurture, to focus on. For many people it’s a partner, or children, a pet or a garden perhaps. For me it’s my art and my shop.”

“Before I opened, I put a teaser video on my Instagram of the sign being painted and I captioned it: ‘I’m opening a sort of shop in a few months time, watch this space’. Most of the comments were really positive. But someone wrote – and this is my favourite interaction – ‘good luck, you’ll get all the lonely people on the street coming in,’ and I replied, ‘Maybe I’m lonely’. I was only half joking, because I do want lonely people to come in. One of the surprising things about the shop is that every Friday about half the people are not from the UK. Which is crazy. I have built my following online so there are fans from everywhere. So many people have come in and told me they saw me do a talk in some random place years ago and they became a fan. Humour travels a lot further than you think.”

Now he just needs to get a bell attached to the door so he can hear them come in. *ralph*



SAY WHAT YOU SEA



TURN THE PAGE

Words by Josh Jones
Illustration by Andy Smith



Ralph's publisher, Chris, was banging on about how old-timey nautical sayings have made their way into our every day language, so we figured we'd do a feature on it.

It turns out there are loads and it's all actually quite interesting. Editor Josh Jones had a look into how the salty sailor-life is still speaking to us today.

01. By and large – originally derived from a ship's ability to sail close to the wind (by) and with a following wind (large). Now it means 'in general'. Don't really know why.

02. Under the weather – feeling unwell. Poorly sailors were sent below deck to shelter from the bad weather... while all the other sailors presumably laughed at them behind their backs.

03. Keel over – to fall over. Originally used to describe a ship that's rolled over and started sinking. Now we mainly use this term to describe drunks stumbling over and old people when they die.

04. Long shot – an unlikely attempt. Because cannons might pack a punch but weren't very accurate over distances, you see.

05. Leeway – an amount of freedom. In nautical terms it meant how much a vessel deviated from its course. How much leeway will you give me for these descriptions?

06. Know the ropes – to be familiar with a task. Because sailors had to do all that stuff with ropes all the time, every bleedin' day.

07. Tie up loose ends – to finalise details. Because the last thing a sailor had to do was tie up loose ends before the ship could sail.

08. Aloof – distant. You won't guess this one. It stems from the Dutch word 'loef', (meaning windward), describing a ship that's gotten separated from the fleet as it was sailing higher to the wind.

09. Bottoms up – drink quickly. Because English sailors were allegedly tricked into joining the navy by drinking coins dropped in their beer, they'd neck their drink asap.

10. Chock a Block – packed together tightly. When a sail has been hoisted to its full extent, the 'blocks' in the mechanism that raise everything jam tightly together and cannot move an inch.

11. Cut and run – abandon something. Some say it's from cutting an anchor line, others think it's from cutting the ropes that tied down the sails. Whatever it is, it's to cut something and make a sharp exit.

12. Dutch courage – bravery via intoxication. Supposedly, English sailors spread the rumour that Dutch sailors wouldn't go into battle unless they'd had a good old drink beforehand.

13. Fathom – to get to the bottom of something. Because sailors measure depths in fathoms, don't they? A fathom is 6 foot, in case you wondered. I thought it was more.

Oh, no, that's a league. Turns out that's distance not depth. Whatever.

14. Figurehead – a leader with no actual power. A figurehead is an ornamental carving on the front of the ship. Self-explanatory.

15. Footloose – to be free to do what you want. If you don't tie the bottom part of a sail (the foot) down, it'll flap about in the wind. Nothng to do with Kevin Bacon.

16. Flying colours – to achieve something magnificently. If a ship made it through a battle with little damage and flags proudly flapping, it was said to be 'flying colours'.

17. Hard up – to be in need (of money usually). This comes from the nautical saying 'hard up in a clinch and no knife to cut the seizing', which was used by sailors to refer to being in a bad situation with no solution. Make what you will of that.

18. Long haul – a long time. Comes from having to haul things up on to the boat by hand, which would take ages.

19. Overhaul – to take something apart and redo it. This comes from a member of crew having to go into the rigging and haul the ropes over the sails to stop them chafing.

20. Pipe down – shhhhhh! In the olden days, the boatswain's pipe was used to communicate with the crew. The 'piping down of the hammocks' was the final toot of the day, signalling that the crew could get some rest.

21. Skyscraper – a tall building. This was actually the name of the tiny sail at the top of all the other sails (you know, the one above the skysail), and was used to maximise the wind as much possible. And it probably looked like it was scraping the sky from all the way down on the deck.

22. Slush fund – money on hand. So, after spending a voyage boiling up bones, the

ship's cooks would sell the fat mixture (slush) they'd saved and keep the money for the crew. Gross and generous.

23. Son of a gun – exclamation of anger or surprise. If a child was born on the ship (wives and 'companions' sometimes got onboard), and no one knew who the father was, they were registered as being a 'son of a gun'.

24. Taking turns – two or more people sharing a responsibility to do something. To stop look outs from falling asleep on the job, they'd switch positions when an hourglass ran out. Which they'd turn to get the sand running again.

25. Shot across the bow – a warning. Like a drunk outside a train station pub, a ship would show it was up for a fight with another by firing a cannon... and missing.

26. All at sea – totally muddled. This comes from when a ship could no longer see any land and the existential dread creeping in that it may never, ever see it again.

27. Jury-rig – to improvise. Comes from when a ship or sail got damaged, probably in a storm or something and sailors got to be the A-Team and improvise to make genius fixes.

28. Go overboard – to do something to excess. I guess this comes from sailors sailing too enthusiastically and falling off the side of the ship. Silly billies.

29. First rate – top class, highest quality. This is all about guns. The British navy used to rate their ships from one to six. First rate having 100 guns on board and sixth rate having a measly 20 or so.

30. Run a tight ship – to manage a group strictly so no mistakes are made. Kind of self-explanatory this one isn't it? Keep things tight, don't fall overboard, don't have leaks and you'll get home safe and sound to sell your disgusting fatty slush. *ralph*



Universal Typewriter Co.

**The keeper of typewriters in India:
tinkerer, clacker, preserver**

Words by Radhika Iyengar
Photos by Chandni Gajria



Almost a decade ago, a then 64-year-old Rajesh Palta received an unexpected phone call from a typewriter technician in a small-town near the pink city of Jaipur, India. A scrap dealer was preparing to dismantle a Remington Model 12, a classic American typewriter that was over a hundred years old. Recognising its historical value, the technician persuaded the scrap dealer to hold off, promising to find a buyer. Palta was immediately intrigued. Portable Remington Model 12s were used in the early 20th Century by literary legends like Agatha Christie and George Orwell, both of whom were known to favour the brand. He recalls, “So I transferred the money to the scrap-dealer right away, and drove out the next morning.”

Palta’s race to rescue the Remington from its near destruction was not about the machine alone. His company, Universal Typewriter Company, is tied to his larger ambition of collecting, salvaging, repairing and preserving the clack and charm of an analog era, teetering on the brink of oblivion. Today, Palta owns over 1000 typewriters; each of them functional.

On a balmy afternoon, I meet Palta at his repair shop in New Delhi’s bustling Nehru Place, which overlooks the city’s striking Lotus Temple. He invites me into a small room lit with natural light, which serves as a portal into history. It houses some of the world’s most iconic typewriters. While Palta continues to sell typewriters, the ones populating this room, he clarifies, are not for sale. The collection is vast and varied: from machines made by Mercedes and Hermès, typewriters with keys in Urdu, Russian, Hindi and Tamil; to a 120-year-old, three-bar, charcoal black Corona typewriter. The latter was one of the earliest, commercially-

produced folding typewriters. Each piece comes with its own vintage casing.

The typewriter business began in his family in 1912, when Palta’s grandfather started selling them in British India’s Lahore. Today, Palta has transformed that business into a personal mission to preserve his family’s legacy and the spirit of the typewriting era. Now nearing its 90th year, Universal Typewriter Company stands as one of India’s oldest and most enduring businesses of its kind. He hopes to one day open a museum where enthusiasts can experience these timeless machines.

Can you tell me how Universal Typewriter Company came into being?

In 1912, my grandfather began selling typewriters in Lahore, which was part of British India at the time. He was a sales officer with Remington Rand Incorporated. Our family became known locally as the ‘Palta family-Typewriter Wale’ (loosely translated as, ‘the keepers of the typewriters’). In 1937, my father formally established the business under the name Universal Typewriter, based entirely in Lahore. 10 years later, however, during the Partition, we relocated from Lahore to Bombay, which was then India’s most commercial city. My father considered moving to Delhi a bit later, and eventually, in the early 1950s, he was allotted a shop by the Government of India as compensation for what we had lost in Lahore. By 1951-52, around the time I was born, my father began operating from Delhi. I joined the family business in the early 1970s. Back then, we had a small store in Old Delhi, near the New Delhi Railway Station. After COVID-19, however, we shifted operations to our current office in Nehru Place in the south of the city, which is where we’ve been based for the past five years.

Did your father share any memories of working in Lahore?

Yes, he often told us how he would strap



“That’s how my collection grows: one rescue and one story at a time”



a heavy typewriter onto his bicycle and personally deliver it across Lahore. When we moved to Bombay by train, he could carry only four typewriters. That's all he had to restart the business in India. My mother played a big role in our family's business too. My father used to travel across the country selling typewriters and accessories, including dust covers. When she learned that he was buying them from a tailor, she said, "Bring home the Rexine [British-made pseudo leather material]. I'll stitch the dust covers myself." I still remember rolls of Rexine arriving at home: my mother cutting and sewing the covers, and us packing them in sets of 12. And my father took them on his trips. It was our little family production line.

Today, you have over 1000 vintage typewriters. What inspired you to start collecting them, at a time when the interest in typewriters had started to dim in India?

Well, back in 1990, India was still producing typewriters at scale. In fact, it was among the leading producers globally. That year also marked a turning point: computers began arriving in the Indian market. As a result, typewriter manufacturers began shutting down their operations and the demand rapidly declined. Many typewriter dealers across Delhi and other parts of the country closed their shops. At the time, we genuinely believed our business might not survive but I decided to continue, even though it was difficult. Then, sometime in the early 2000s, my eldest son found two or three old typewriters tucked away in our house: a Smith Corona, Royal and a Remington. They were just lying in the storage as junk. He asked me whether I could repair those machines, to which I said yes. I took them to my workshop and showed them to my technician, who had one look at them and said that the repair cost of the machines would be higher than their worth. But still, I got them repaired. When I brought the restored machines home, my children introduced me to the world of typewriters

on the internet, especially to the growing interest in vintage machines internationally. That's when I realised that these fully restored typewriters, the kind we had been treating as scrap, were being valued at USD 1000 or more abroad. That was the turning point. I stopped discarding old typewriters and began collecting them seriously. Since then, my collection has kept growing.

How did the Remington become a household favourite in India?

The Remington became the most popular typewriter brand in India largely due to timing and policy. Before 1947, typewriters were manufactured only in Europe and America. After independence, however, the Indian government restricted the import of typewriters and allowed only those companies which agreed to set up local manufacturing through technical collaborations to operate. Remington Rand Inc., USA, was the first to do so. They established Remington Rand of India Ltd. and set up a manufacturing unit in Howrah, near Calcutta. As a result, Remington typewriters dominated the Indian market through the 1950s, '60s and '70s. It wasn't until the late '70s that other brands entered the scene. Eventually, four major brands were manufactured in India: alongside Remington, Swedish manufacturers Facit and Halda, and India's very own, Godrej. In fact, Godrej was the first company to produce all-Indian typewriters in the early '50s, and, in 2009, its Godrej Prima was recorded as the last manual typewriter [to be mass-produced globally] in the world.

Over the years, how have you pieced your collection together?

People often ask me, 'Where do you find these machines?' Since our family has been in the typewriter trade for generations, we're known across the country, and many old technicians reach out to us directly. About 10 years ago, a small-town technician near Jaipur called to say that he had found a Remington Model 12 machine. That immediately rang

a bell in my mind because I knew he meant a typewriter that was over 100 years old. It was with a kabaadi (scrap dealer), about to be dismantled. I immediately sent the scrap dealer money online and drove out the next morning. When I arrived, there were six machines: one wrecked but five still intact. That's how my collection grows: one rescue and one story at a time. Another big source for typewriters is government departments and embassies auctioning off their typewriters. For example, in Kerala, the state government recently auctioned off 85 typewriters. Through such platforms, we clean each machine and weave it into gold by making it functional.

How has the demographic of your clientele changed over the last few decades?

We've been restoring typewriters since long before computers arrived. Back then, most of our work involved repairing office machines; fixing wear-and-tear from daily use. Today, the purpose is entirely different. The people coming in now aren't office workers, they're writers, collectors and enthusiasts. For example, a young man recently visited our shop looking for a typewriter. I showed him a few portable models, and he picked one, paid for it, and said, "I'm heading to the hills now to write. I was just waiting to get this." Six months later, he messaged me on WhatsApp, saying, "Mr. Palta, I've just published my first collection of short stories. All were typed on the machine I bought from you." So, that's the shift. People are turning to typewriters not out of necessity, but for inspiration, and for freedom from distraction.

In a fast-paced digital world, do you think we're losing something that typewriters once gave us – like the meditative nature of typing or a sense of permanence?

Yes, especially that idea of permanence. I remember a senior legal professional once visited my shop. He had a remarkable collection of typewriters and Indian film memorabilia. He said something that I often

"People are turning to typewriters not out of necessity, but for inspiration, and for freedom from distraction"

repeat to others: "The tragedy of today's world is the use-and-throw mindset. Not just with technological gadgets and tools, but with relationships too. We no longer repair relationships; we replace them." That statement remains with me. The beauty of a typewriter is that it can be repaired, reused and repaired again. Typewriters remind us to value things that last. A good typewriter, if cared for, can work for over 100 years. That's the kind of durability and mindset that we're losing. Owning a typewriter, might remind us to hold onto these values.

What continues to fascinate you about typewriters?

I often call the typewriter the father of all computers – and one of the greatest inventions of the last century. Back in the 1990s, when Godrej was still making typewriters, their salespeople told me something remarkable: a refrigerator has around 270 parts; a typewriter has over 2000. The level of precision required for a typewriter's alignment is incredible. It's not just a machine – it's a marvel of engineering.

You mentioned that you're thinking of writing a memoir. Will it be written on a typewriter?

Of course! I still type at around 50 words a minute. If I ever write my memoir, it will be written either on an Olivetti or an Olympia. *ralph*

How to **WIN** Against *History*

A brilliant play about a person almost entirely
erased from the record books

Words by Ben Smoke
Photos by Pamela Raith





Sorry to break it to you but, unless your name is Jesus, Achilles or perhaps Cher, the likelihood is that at some point you will be forgotten. You will live on in the memories of people around you or in the things you write or create after you pass. As those people, memories or things fade or pass themselves, the waves of time will slowly wipe us away. It is the natural order of things. Like the tallest mountains slowly worn down by wind and rain, so too are we gradually eroded. There is, I think, a comfort in the slowness and the inevitability of it all.

What happens then, when the memories, notes, photos and the mere mention of someone – the very things that tie them to this corporeal world – are intentionally dashed? When they are willingly and purposefully expunged from history? This is the fate that befell Henry Cyril Paget, a 19th century Welsh aristocrat.

Paget was born 150 years ago and, left motherless at an early age, was raised by relatives in Paris, where he was exposed to theatre and cabaret circles that were booming in the city and would leave a lifelong impression on him. Dragged kicking and screaming back to Wales by a brutish father who would soon also die (a lot of it going around), Paget became the 5th Marquis of Anglesey, aged just 23. Over the next six years, Paget, in somewhat iconic fashion, managed to blow his entire family fortune putting on garish and gauche plays... starring himself.

Paget converted the chapel at his family's historic Plas Newydd estate into the 'Gaeity Theatre' putting on performances dressed in lavish, inheritance-busting costumes. Paget died a penniless pauper in Monaco aged 29, having trashed his family's name and all the riches that came with it. Or that's how the

story goes – his family, in an act of vengeance, destroyed all records of him, save for a few photos, where he's dressed to the nines in the fabulous and fantastic costumes that wrought his destruction. They expunged Paget from memories, and he would lie, but for those few photos hung in a toilet somewhere in his mansion, almost forgotten.

Enter Seiriol Davies, award-winning writer, composer, songwriter and performer from rural Wales. Over the last decade, Davies, alongside longstanding collaborators Matthew Blake and Dylan Townley, have been exploring the life of Henry Paget via the medium of their hit show, *How To Win Against History*.

"We started at the Edinburgh Fringe Festival in 2016," Blake, who plays a variety of different characters in the show including Mr Alexander Keith, Paget's theatrical co-conspirator, tells me. We're sitting in the empty stalls of the Old Vic in Bristol after a packed out matinée performance of the show. "It was a tiny, tiny little show, just three idiots and a piano in a little shipping container, which we nicknamed 'the microwave' because it was so hot."

Townley, who is the show's musical director as well as playing Maestro on stage, joins in: "I was taller than the lighting rig in that space, and I spent a lot of time wearing the version we had of Henry's winged helmet for that show," he laughs. "So I was standing there with these wings, knocking out all the lights."

The show took the Fringe by storm, receiving rave reviews and resulting in a nationwide tour in 2017. It was during this run that the show drew the attention of Francesca Moody, the visionary producer behind hits like *Fleabag* and *Baby Reindeer*. "We actually met up for something completely different a few years after the original Edinburgh run," explains Davies, who as well as playing Paget, has written every iteration of the show. "Francesca was like 'what's happening with *How to Win*? It's one of my favourite shows

I've ever seen'. From there we just started to make plots and scheme how we would bring it back."

The result is a show really without par. A gold-leafed slice of theatrical genius, devoured by audiences the country over. It follows the story of Paget from early life into death and beyond, in a raucous and unrelenting musical that takes in huge, bold, ungainly topics like empire, queerness, history and truth, and spits them out into glittery silly morsels.

"The whole idea is to provide audiences with a hell of a good night out," Seiriol tells me, "and hopefully leave them with some ideas that they might not otherwise have thought of, or maybe they have thought those things and it gives them an arena in which to celebrate them."

The show is undeniably queer, but it is not, as Davies says, "a show by queer people for queer people." The matinée they just finished performing was full of a range of people that, perhaps, one would not envisage watching an all-singing, all-dancing queer spectacle and yet they laughed, cheered and cried along until the bitter end.

"Assumptions about audiences and what they will or will not accept is responsible for a lot of cowardly programming and battle line drawing," Davies explains of the diverse audience. "I think there's a large extent to which it's not necessary. If you just provide something that's really fun, then people will bring their nans to it – and their uncles who spend too much time on Facebook and probably believe that grass isn't real."

As we speak, crew members are hoovering up piles of confetti and resetting the stage, ready for the evening's performance. Around a central podium sits a lavish set, which includes a grand piano (which at points doubles as horses, cars, and an extra stage), ferns, and a chaise longue. The live music performances comes from a cast of incredible

musicians who, somewhat inevitably, get swept up in the silliness. At every level, from the pre-curtain up, Edwardian reimagining of party hits like 'YMCA', to the grandiose costumes that cloak Davies as they speed run through Paget's life, silliness, and indeed frivolity, are front and centre.

Transpose Paget from his time to ours and he would be the worst sort of nepo baby. So how do you make a show that is so popular and joyful about a man who, for all intents and purposes, should be deeply unlikeable? How do you centre the mocking of the frivolity of the upper classes, with a joyful celebration of frivolity as a central tenant of the queer experience?

"It's a tricky one isn't it?" Davies ponders aloud. "None of us wanted to make it like a poor-little-rich-boy story, but Shakespeare writes about kings because they can make mistakes on a bigger canvas. Their successes are bigger, their failures are bigger, so really Paget's massive resources are key to the story. You're only going to get so much story out of a fancy-doodle peasant."

Our conversation descends, I'm not afraid to admit, into a tangent about an imagined Henry Paget as a peasant, with all the ploughing (oh, matron!) based puns you can imagine that come with it. When we settle back into a modicum of sensibility, Davies continues, "If you've ever looked at the pictures of actual Henry, there is something out-of-his-time about him. There's a lostness to him. And because all of his letters and diaries and everything were annihilated, we don't know any of his internal life. He's basically just an empty vessel. I'm not saying queer erasure is a great thing, but in some ways it's been great for the show! Erase us more, and we'll come back with shows!"

Davies describes the show, which exists in a liminal space between now and then, as if Henry had come back from the dead, knowing only that which is on his Wikipedia page. It is where his relentless optimism

"If you provide something that's really fun, then people will bring their nans to it – and their uncles who spend too much time on Facebook and probably believe that grass isn't real"





“He didn’t understand the concept of costume jewellery, so he had his outfits made with actual diamonds”

and naivety, delivered with expert tongue-pushed-firmly-into-cheek, comes from. I posit that the show draws similarities to historical dramas like *The Crown* in its ability to take a set of historical flag poles and weave between them deeply compelling stories about the human experience. “Ours, somehow, has less ghosts in it than *The Crown* though,” co-star Blake cuts in, laughing.

It’s this reimagining of the truth of someone’s life that is the key tenet of the show. History is written by the winners, and all so often those winners look, sound and originate from the same very narrow space in society. It so often erases the stories, experiences and truths of, for example, queer people, sowing the seeds for contemporary derision or division.

“We reject the idea of history,” Davies says, chewing over the central conceit of their work in pulling the show together. “The idea of winning in history for us is to say there is no such thing as a history that we can rely on. We have the myth of Henry Cyril Paget, we have the truth, and truth is different to fact

because fact is curated by people who have power, but truth is for everyone.” As the interview draws to a close I ask what they think Paget would make of the show?

“He’d probably think it looks cheap,” Davies laughs, “Because he didn’t understand the concept with costume jewellery. So he would have his outfits made of actual diamonds. And he actually, in real life, left those costumes in the dressing room, where they got nicked. Those diamonds were worth more than his house – and the house was fucking huge. But hopefully he’d be delighted by the show.”

“He’d probably want to be in it and get rid of you,” Blake playfully jibes.

“I think there is a lot of tenderness in the show for him, and there’s a lot of clemency for being someone different in an age that hated that,” Davies says, before adding: “although we get asked this a lot and, to be honest, I don’t know because I have no idea who he is. Maybe he was an absolute c*nt?”

We’ll never know. *ralph*



Styling by Way Perry Assisted by Emily Bulford Grooming by Bianca Simone Scott



FEKKY'S FARM FARM

One rapper's journey from stage to stable

Words by Ben Smoke
Photos by Jessica Eliza Ross





This page: Fekky wears all Wax London, wellingtons: Hunter Boots, cap: Borsalino
 Preceding page: Jacket & jeans: Wax London, belt: Gucci, cap: Palace

UK rapper Fekky is a force to be reckoned with. An extremely successful solo artist in his own right, with seven albums under his belt, his own record label, collaborations with the likes of Dizzee Rascal and Skepta, and having played stages most musicians can only dream of. In 2021, after a lockdown epiphany, the Londoner left the city to move to a farm. The only problem? He didn't know anything about farming.

Determined to remedy this, Fekky has produced, directed, and fronted a new YouTube series called *Hood 2 Farm*, in which we follow him immersing himself in farming—learning traditional skills, exploring sustainability, and redefining what it means to reconnect with the land, all while bringing his signature humour, youthful energy, and charismatic storytelling to the screen.

We caught up with him at his friend's farm, Organic Orchards, in Essex to discuss this new journey, giving back to his community and his love of cows and chickens.

You've had an incredible music career. How have you gone from performing to enormous crowds to clearing out chicken coops?

At the beginning of my career all my music was shot in my area. I was rapping with my friends, and then it just blew up. When I got signed, things got even crazier. From 2011, I'd just been touring, hotel to hotel, never spending a night in my house. You never realise how much it's taking out of you when you're doing these shows, you're drinking so much, and just having a wild, fun time! When I got to the farm, I realised I had just been on autopilot and found actual peace.

So what was the trigger to slow yourself down?

Lockdown. Lockdown made me stop. Like I said, when you're in your career, you're just

going and going and going. So you don't actually have time to stop and reflect. When lockdown hit, I was in Thailand for about three months and it just made me fall in love with nature. When I came back to the UK, which was still locked down, I was just doing gardening and stuff like that. It made me realise there was a bit more to life than the glitz, the glam, and the wild crazy life. That's what made me realise I just want to help people and do more things and spend more time with my family.

What if lockdown hadn't happened?

That's a good question. I honestly don't know, but I think everything in life's meant to happen, so in a way lockdown was meant to happen for me. Obviously, it was a bad thing for the world. But for me, it got me thinking about life. I had a whiteboard, I was writing my five year plan. I was reading books, training every day. I was making smoothies with berries in them. I went from champagne to smoothies! Honestly! It brought me to a positive space. I opened a charity, and I started questioning what I was putting back into the universe. Basically in lockdown, I got to catch up with myself.

Farming is so different to everything that came before, and you can tell from watching *Hood 2 Farm* the genuine love and respect that you have for it. Where did that come from, and how did you approach making it?

I feel like in anything you do, community and culture are important. I could have started the show just doing stuff on my farm, but I wanted to actually go around and learn from farmers and actually become part of the community. When I first moved to my farm, I was surprised how my neighbours and I all got on, coming from different backgrounds. When I first went to the other farms, I thought I'd be out of my depth. So *Hood 2 Farm* was literally me saying, "Look, let me go around to other farms, meet different farmers, and just learn the culture,

and learn how to farm before I come back and actually start building my own farm.” It was a surprising journey, because I got on with every farmer. I feel like when you’re from the hood, we’re looked at as like, ‘Oh, he’s a wrong’un, he’s a troublemaker.’ On top of that with my rap and my content, you just wouldn’t think that I’d get along with a 70-year-old farmer. But I do!

You visited lots of different farms – did you have a favourite?

My favourite farm was my farm! But out of all the ones I visited, I think my favourite was the cows episode. A lot of farmers are lonely, because you have to man your land a lot of the time yourself. The cost of running a farm is not cheap, and a lot of people do it themselves. What I liked about the cow farm was that they have a community. They have a shop, they have people coming back and forth, and they’re selling milk. These are the things I want to do on my farm. I want to make sure I’ve got a place where people can come, they can buy fresh produce. They can have a pub with food that’s made with things that I’m growing. You can stay over. We’ll have pods there. I’ve got big dreams for my farm. So that was the farm that I saw and made me think, ‘You know what? This is how I’d like my farm to be.’

You talk in the series about the food bank you help run through your charity CC Foundation and wanting the produce you grow to go there. Some might think calling the show *Hood 2 Farm* means you’re trying to escape to the country, but you still love your London community, right?

That’s where I grew up. That’s what made me who I am today. So when I started my charity, it was about giving back to my area. We do employability classes, open days with big brands, lessons on personal finance. I like to do what I can, and I get so much support. A lot of amazing people support us, like Ed Sheeran and AJ Tracy, and I’m grateful to be in the position to be able to do

that, to help my area. We have a food bank in Lewisham where produce from the farm goes to give back to the community. When I first had an egg from my chickens, I couldn’t believe the difference in taste from my eggs to supermarket ones, or my peppers or my apples. Everything just tastes better, and it’s because it’s organic. I wanted to make sure that the people in the community see that and get to have that.

As well as helping to give back, you have also spoken about how farming has helped your mental health.

I feel like a lot of the time now, we’re all controlled by our mobile phones. When you’re sitting there scrolling, you’re not actually living in the moment. When you’re on the farm, you’re doing something – you’re feeding the chickens, or you’re watering the plants, or you’re building sheds. When I’m doing work I don’t even know where my phone is. I’m literally just working and I feel that mentally, it really helps, because you get to switch off from having to watch everybody else’s life.

Being on a farm brings calm, it brings peace, it balances your mental health. And you can actually go to farms and visit, be with animals. No one ever tells you that. You can take your kids to farms and stuff. This is why I want my farm to be that place for people from my community, where you can come and just experience the life that I’m living. I want it to be for everyone, I don’t want it to feel like it’s just me on the farm. I want it to be like, ‘come to the farm and enjoy. Look at apples on the trees. Come and take some apples. Go make an apple pie.’

Farming is, undeniably, very hard work. Yet the passion you have for it, and the joy you have in doing it in the show is infectious. How do you keep up the enthusiasm?

You should always do what you love. When you’re doing that, it doesn’t feel like work. I feel like a lot of people are doing what

Shirt & jeans: Wax London, wellingtons: Hunter Boots, sunglasses: Vintage Frames Company



“It’s very important to know what you’re eating, where it’s coming from and how it’s made”



Jacket & jeans: Wax London, wellingtons: Hunter Boots, cap: Palace

they have to do to put food on the table, and you might be going to a job which you don’t necessarily love. You just have to pay the bills. A lot of farmers are not actually making crazy money, but it’s a lifestyle. They enjoy the lifestyle. You have relationships with your animals, and with nature. So that’s what keeps me happy and I can’t wait for it to be full time. I’m still doing other things, and I’m running the charity and I’m doing my music. I’ve got an album I’m working on, but eventually farming will just be full time.

So you have had time to make new music?

I’m working on an album at the moment, which I hope to bring out next year. I’ve been dropping music over the last couple of years, but I’ve not actually been dropping it with any intention. I’ve just been trying to feed my core fan base. Because everywhere I go, people are asking ‘where’s the music?!’ The latest things I’ve dropped over the last few years have had more positive messaging in, and slowly and surely I’m maturing as an artist. I’m happy that I’ve taken time to step back and experience life a bit outside of playing shows. I’m a bit older now so I feel like my music needs to reflect the honesty of me in life. I feel like I’m going to have a balance in my music where you’ll be inspired and get some gems. So I’m excited about the next album coming out – maybe next year... and don’t worry, I’m not going to be rapping about cows and chickens.

So what comes next for the farm and the series?

I think there’s a bit more for me to go around and do. We’ve done eight episodes, and when we started the journey, I didn’t realise how much there is to learn. I feel like I want to learn more about horses! So I’ll be visiting more farms and we’re going to push it out a bit and go further afield – up to Scotland and across to Ireland. Then for season three we’re going to go round the world. I think farming around the world is very different, a bit more crazy. I want to go to Texas, to China, just to see the different ways of farming. When I was in Africa, I saw the culture of farming and how everyone does it. Young kids are taught farming from a young age, which is different to over here. The farming community over here is very old, and this is where I come in. I’m coming to save the community! [laughs]

I’m a young farmer, and I want to encourage the youth to understand what they’re eating. It’s very important to know what you’re eating, where it’s coming from, and how it’s made. That’s why I want to go to these countries where the farming community is a lot younger and show everyone that. And then the big dream is *Fekky’s Farm Show*, where everybody watches me build my farm out from the beginning. They’ll see me being with the animals, opening the pub and the shop, all that sort of thing. *ralph*

MISO EXTRA'S MISO EXTRA'S SUMMER BANGERS SUMMER BANGERS

Miso Extra has had a huge 2026, including a European tour, big sets at Glastonbury and End of the Road festivals and supporting Sabrina Carpenter. The fast-rising, anime-influenced, soon-to-be-massive pop artist gave us her favourite songs of the summer.

Heaven

Ebo Taylor

Badder

Shermanology, Champion

still wanna hold u

SAMSON

Friends

Hannes

āfa

15 15

Anymore

Becky and the Birds

Peace in Your Heart

Obongjayar

Money Fight

DERBY

Dangerous Moves

HIRA

Bound

Wet, Blood Orange

Miso Extra's album *Earcandy*
is out now on Transgressive



SCAN TO LISTEN

BULK

An exclusive behind the scenes look at Ben Wheatley's brain-busting new film *BULK*. Using incredible hand-built sets, it stars Alexandra Maria Lara, Sam Riley, Noah Taylor, and Mark Monero. "Bulk is a midnight movie," the award-winning director tells us. "Like something you would have stumbled across on Channel 4 in the '80s and spent the next 20 years trying to find out what that crazy film was."

BULK is about an overzealous scientist who pushes his experiments with string theory so far his brane explodes. It's not a typo, a 'brane' is a generalised concept of a physical object that can extend into higher spatial dimensions. That concept has manifested as a normal townhouse - one where opening a door from one room to another can lead you to other worlds, not just the kitchen.

Photos by Andy Starke/Nick Gillespie



"It's hand-made - a cottage industry of cast and crew - formed by everyone involved"

Ben Wheatley



“We wanted to go back to old techniques of film-making – rear projection, models and matte paintings, post synching, and stop motion – to create a unique world and a unique film”

Ben Wheatley





BULK premiered as part of Midnight Madness at the Edinburgh Fringe Festival and will be in UK cinemas soon

NIGHT MAYOR NIGHT



The secrets behind throwing a great party

Words by Josh Jones
Photos by Karen Stanley & Courtney Frisby

MAYOR NIGHT

Clayton Wright is an extremely busy person. A pioneer of queer nightlife and UK club culture, he's Creative Director and owner of club nights such as Feel It (which he runs with drag icon Jodie Harsh), Little Gay Brother and Studland Soho, as well as two queer music festivals - Body Movements and False Idols. So, to continue Ralph's How To... series, who better to give us the inside story on how to run a club night?

Why do you throw so many parties? Is it all about creating somewhere for people to have a load of fun?

For me, the point is to create a space where queer people can come together and be themselves. When we're in a space which is truly ours, we can be ourselves. You don't have to watch over your shoulder, and you're free to be a filthy slag, essentially. And that's what it's really about. It's about having a lovely time and being as sexually free as you can be.

Do you get stressed during the night? You don't get to relax even when the doors are open?

It is a stressful thing. In fact I was recently told that I give 'fuck off' vibes – by some

very sexy men, which I was a bit sad about, but I'm always in full work mode. Because I care a lot that everyone's having fun, I don't actually have much fun myself. It'd be weird if I was there at the front having the most fun – that would be a bit like getting high off my own supply or something. Recently I was at Brighton Pride, standing in the lighting booth, screaming, "kiss me", but no one could hear me over the very loud speakers.

Because you put on a night where the sound was such high quality...?

SUCH high quality. The Funktion-One Soundsystem is cock blocking me all the time.

Do you still get that 'what if no one's going to come' pre-party nervousness?

Yeah, sometimes. Because if we have a few bad weeks in a row with my night *Feel It*, things would get pretty tricky. Each party has to be so good that people want to come to the next one, so people are always talking about it. Something mad has to happen to whet people's appetite, so they feel like they've missed out and that's something *Feel It* does well. We don't pre-sell tickets to *Feel It* because we want it to feel like a gay *Cheers*, where you can just come down, everybody knows your name, everybody's seen your penis, and everyone really celebrates that.

Talking of mad things happening, you had Charli XCX at the height of brat come along to *Feel It*.

Charli locked herself out of her house, she turned up with no shoes, and drank two bottles of champagne. She looked at me, and we were like, 'we're going to be friends'. And instantly we were. Even though I have sat at her table before.

That was at the NME Awards! I was with you!

It was! And we were booted off. She probably still thinks I am Ronnie Wood's son, because that's what I told everyone that night (I'm not). Maybe that's why she came to my night. She was like, 'Oh, I've got to do it. Because, you know, his dad's part of the Rolling Stones.'

You also had Jade Thirlwall perform live at *Feel It*. How do you keep that stuff under wraps?

Well, normally I've got a big gob, but sometimes we'll let it slip to our friends because we want the night to be packed. And sometimes we don't announce that stuff, because we want to keep it authentically queer and for our audience, so we're always balancing that. We want the right people to come, who are going to appreciate the night and the artist at the same time. But we've never really had that problem when we have a huge artist like Charli XCX, Jessie Ware or Jade – we get queues around the block, but it just adds to what *Feel It* is. Every week brings something different and brings different people down. Last week, we had 50 guys dressed up as Spider-Man, and they all started getting it on in the toilets. That is what keeps *Feel It* alive. Insert web joke here.

You've had to brief the security in venues that working at a queer night is not the same as a gig, and that's changed the way they looked at dealing with the public. Do you still find that?

Yeah, I've changed a lot of London venues'

policies around inclusion, and that's everywhere from fabric, Printworks, Omeara, and anywhere we've done gigs. We've had to educate them on queer people, how they dress differently, how they behave, what is appropriate, how to search trans people and non-binary bodies at the door. Even the most basic things like smiling and saying hello to customers, which you would think would be what most people do. But a lot of security believe that they are there to police the party. Security are not the police, they are literally there to keep people safe. So you've got to remind them that they are here to welcome people, and if they don't, they're not allowed on my door.

As well as *Feel It* you've got other club nights and two festivals. That's a lot of things to juggle, your phone must never stop.

I don't have a life. I hardly go to other people's parties anymore, but I clearly am addicted to what I do. I love queer music, festivals, and club nights. When I was growing up and finding and exploring my queerness, the majority of my friends were straight, and I didn't feel like I really belonged on a queer scene. So I wanted to create spaces that spoke to me, spoke to the music I liked, and felt more inclusive. And that's how my *Little Gay Brother* project started, which in turn led me to starting *Body Movements Festival*, and *False Idols* at Drumsheds in north London. And I've seen these spaces, especially big places like Drumsheds and Printworks, and told them that queer people deserve to be in them. I suppose that's what keeps me motivated and going. Working on lots of things means that I can speak to lots of different parts of the community. So *Body Movements* is a lot more femme and trans leaning in its approach and music policy, whereas *Feel It* is a bit more of a gay boy party, and that's fine – there's enough space for all of us. We don't have to be lumped into the same space. What I realised is no-one is going to give you the opportunity. If you're upset about not





having that visibility, go and create it yourself, because there's people out there that will get behind you.

Would you say the secret to a running a successful club night is to keep it small, organic and find your audience first?

I would say always keep it small and build from there. Sometimes I have gone too big and fucked myself over. There's more queer stuff than there's ever been before, so there's so much choice, and people like different experiences. *Little Gay Brother* is 12 years old, and I've had to keep it fresh – something I've also had to do with *Feel It, Body Movements* and *False Idols*. You really have to evolve and give people something new, because nothing lasts forever unless you keep reinventing things and keep making things current. I think when it comes to the bigger stuff, you have to be ballsy and confident. If you don't think you're ever going to be able to do it, you won't. That's what it's about. You just have to have blind confidence in yourself and your ability. I think it always pays off if you believe in yourself.

And is the venue important?

Yeah, fully. London is actually quite sad for queer venues. A lot of our events happen all in the same places, because there's not a variety of amazing spaces that allow the hedonism, freedom or the approach to queer people that we need. That's why so many people go abroad and find things in places like Berlin or Mexico. Venues can over police queer stuff when it's just not necessary, and it's the over policing that can really kill the vibe. No-one wants to be judged on a door about what you're wearing, then judged on a dance floor, with someone constantly looking over your shoulder. If I wanted that, I'd invite my mum out on a Friday night.

What are your views on lanyards – are they cool or not?

Lanyards are way cooler than wristbands. A lanyard say 'I'm being paid to be here'. Wristbands say 'I bought a ticket'.

Can you get me plus 13 on the next guest list?

Absolutely. But there is a mandatory guest list donation to Trans Pride. *ralph*

Clayton's top tips to running a club night

1. Have a good crew around you

Nightlife is a very hard, demanding, crazy place, and if your crew around you aren't sane and supportive, you can get into a black hole... or another hole, and that's hard to get out of. So avoid the holes.

2. Think it through from a customer's point of view

What do you care about? What's the situation in the toilets? How's security going to talk to you? What's the bar service like? If you don't know what the customer is going to experience and you don't think about that, then they're going to have a shit time. And you're a shit promoter.



3. You don't need big money and big talent to throw a great party

Some of the best parties are built around emerging talent and new music. New artists are hungry to entertain people and that's actually how community is built: fostering new artists and DJs.



4. Throw in some surprises where you can

You're giving a service at the end of the day, and you want to surprise people as much as possible.



5. Don't always take it so seriously

We're all here to have fun at the end of the day, and if you don't remind yourself of that, your party's going to be fucking dry.



6. Don't pre-drink

You don't need to. You won't be able to get shit done.





LOU ADLER

ALL HAIL
THE KING OF
POP CULTURE!

Words by Kevin E G Perry
Photos by Jesse Lirola
Styling by Raquel Rocky Deriane
Hair and Makeup by Shannon Pezzetta

Lou Adler walks into The Roxy on LA's Sunset Strip like he owns the place, because he does. He rolls in through a side door in a slouchy white beanie that matches the frames of his shades, his neat, snowy beard and his baggy long-sleeved shirt, looking like he just sidled off a billboard promoting some impossibly hip streetwear brand. As he surveys the early afternoon scene, taking in the empty stage and the crouched bartender restocking drinks, I head over to introduce myself and realise I might be in the presence of the coolest 91-year-old alive. Lou is more than a legend of music and movies. He's the living embodiment of the California dream.

By the time he threw open the doors of this iconic venue in 1973, Lou was already a Grammy-winning record producer and songwriter who'd played a not insignificant role in the birth of the modern music festival. Within another decade, he'd added box-office-smashing film producer and cult comedy director to his already staggering CV. After that, he eased back on the work commitments to concentrate on raising his sons – all seven of them.

Lou, as you can tell, does not do things by halves. He's fine-tuned pop hits with Sam Cooke, Carole King and The Mamas & the Papas, sparked stoner gags with Cheech and Chong and partied with Jack Nicholson. He's seen, heard and smoked it all. Later, I'll make the mistake of wondering out loud if some pivotal moment of LA history happened before his time. Lou will laugh, and deadpan: "Nothing is before my time."

He introduces me to his long-haired, hippie-ish wife Page, sister of *Kill Bill* star Darryl Hannah. Then we all head upstairs, moving through the bowels of the club until we reach a discreet backstage dressing room. Lou takes a seat on a couch beneath a black-and-white photo of a young Prince making his LA debut downstairs in 1979. He gestures for me to turn on my recording device. "One, two,

three, four..." he says into the microphone. Always the producer, but this time LA's maestro-behind-the-scenes is here to tell his own story.

Lou likes to say he got his start in the music industry because of a girl. He was 23 in 1956 when an old girlfriend fixed him up with a friend of hers so they could double date with her boyfriend, just back from the Korean War. That was Herb Alpert, the virtuoso trumpeter who'd go on to become a major star of the Sixties with his band the Tijuana Brass.

When they first met, Lou and Herb were just two ambitious kids from Boyle Heights in east LA who wanted to write songs. They landed a job at a label named Keen Records, and Lou wound up living in a hotel on Hollywood Boulevard with their star artist, Sam Cooke. Lou and Herb tried to write for him, but Sam had notes. "Herbie and I had a song that we'd started... 'You don't know a book from its cover, you don't have to be... something... to be a lover...'," Lou sings, humming the lilting melody. "I showed Sam the song, and he said: 'I like it, but it should be younger.' It was his idea to make it about school." They rewrote the lyrics to reference science books and the "French I took" and the result was 'Wonderful World', one of the biggest hits Sam ever had.

Soon, Lou was displaying an enviable knack for being in the right place at the right time. He managed surf rockers Jan & Dean before live recording the debut album *At The Whisky a Go Go* by rock'n'roller Johnny Rivers, just a couple of doors down from where we're sitting. In 1965, he produced Barry McGuire's chart-topping protest anthem 'Eve of Destruction', and McGuire recommended he check out rising folkies The Mamas & The Papas. They turned up armed with tunes that became era-defining classics, including 'Monday, Monday' and 'California Dreamin''. When he talks about hearing their voices in harmony for the first time, Lou leans in and his tone turns reverential.



**“The Who
started
smashing their
instruments so
Hendrix thought:
‘Well I can’t
break my guitar,
so I’ll set it
on fire’”**





"I had a habit of closing my eyes when I auditioned artists, imagining how they would feel on radio," he whispers. "I closed my eyes and they started singing... I couldn't believe it. Then I opened my eyes and, I mean, they were coming off about 80 acid trips! Michelle was the most beautiful California girl. John was 6'4", hugely tall for a rock'n'roll singer. I got the title to their first album in that moment: *If You Can Believe Your Eyes And Ears*."

Lou produced the band's first four records, helping shape the 'California sound' and forming a creative partnership with their chief songwriter, John Phillips. Together, they organised Monterey Pop in 1967 – the first major international music festival in the US. Janis Joplin, The Who, Otis Redding and Ravi Shankar were all introduced to a mass audience, while Jimi Hendrix seared himself into pop culture by dropping to his knees and setting his guitar alight.

It was Lou who had to stop the fire department shutting everything down when Hendrix's guitar went up. "It turned out to be a thing between Hendrix and Pete Townshend of The Who," Lou explains, shaking his head. "Each was trying to outdo the other. The Who started smashing their instruments so Hendrix thought: 'Well I can't break it, so I'll set it on fire.'"

Hendrix's wild antics ended up working to Lou's advantage. Lou had helped fund the festival by doing a deal to sell the television rights to ABC Paramount, but really he wanted to keep the footage to make his own film with director D. A. Pennebaker. At a meeting after the festival, Lou showed the studio boss a clip of Hendrix provocatively humping his guitar amp. "The guy that ran ABC Paramount was a very proper Southern gentleman," recalls Lou with a mischievous twinkle. "He just said: 'Not on my network!' and gave the footage back to us."

The success of the Monterey Pop documentary helped Lou gain the respect of Hollywood, but he wasn't done with music

production just yet. He had signed up-and-coming singer-songwriter Carole King to his label Ode and in 1971 produced her record-breaking album *Tapestry*. It went on to sell more than 25 million copies and saw Carole and Lou take home Grammys for Record of the Year (for single 'It's Too Late') and Album of the Year.

Lou's philosophy for the album had been to make it sound like Carole was in the room with you, playing her piano. Closing his eyes, he heard in her songwriting a similar intelligence to that shown by Sam Cooke and John Phillips. "They were all very smart," says Lou. "They were all educated, even if it wasn't a formal education. They were curious, and they put that into their writing. Sam took gospel and put it into rock'n'roll, and John did the same with folk. Carole was the most rock'n'roll educated. She'd been writing songs since she was 15."

It wasn't just music that Lou had an ear for. One night in 1971 he was at The Troubadour when he saw two guys on stage crawling around sniffing each other's butts pretending to be dogs. He immediately knew he wanted to record them for his label and the pair, known as Cheech and Chong, went on to become stoner comedy icons. Lou produced all their albums himself, and unlike the stripped-back approach he took to recording Carole, here he set about creating 'ear movies' by adding texture and sound effects to help sell the gags. "I called it hard rock comedy," Lou tells me. "Wherever there was a rock'n'roll audience, they could be there. They were booked to open for Bob Marley here at The Roxy. That was memorable... and smoky. Very smoky."

Lou helped transform Cheech and Chong into comedy superstars, and was determined to bring them to the big screen. He did a deal with Paramount to produce their first film, the epic road comedy *Up In Smoke* about a couple of stoners who drive a van made of weed from Tijuana to Los Angeles before



“To work with Neil Young is just an extension of working with Sam Cooke, Carole King and John Phillips. He’s such an intelligent writer”

playing in a battle of the bands here at The Roxy. Then the director dropped out. "The guy was only there for a day, I don't think he even got to put a camera up! Cheech and Chong hated him," explains Lou. "I had a meeting at Paramount, and the guy said: 'Why don't you direct it?'"

If there was a steep learning curve involved in moving from the production desk to the director's chair, it didn't seem to bother Lou. "There were two things that helped," he shrugs modestly. "I had produced all their albums, so I knew the material well, and I grew up in Boyle Heights, so I knew who Cheech was, that character that he did very well." The film was a massive hit. Produced for \$2 million, about half of which was Lou's own money, it raked in \$104 million at the box office.

Next, Lou directed *Ladies and Gentlemen, The Fabulous Stains*, the story of an all-female punk band who provoke riots wherever they go. Released in 1982, it helped launch the careers of baby-faced actors Diane Lane, Laura Dern and Ray Winstone and featured appearances from punk icons like Steve Jones and Paul Cook of the Sex Pistols and Paul Simonon from the Clash.

The film bombed at the box office but went on to inspire countless musicians, with Bikini Kill crediting it for influencing the riot grrl movement and Kate Nash admitting she ripped off her skunk-haired early look from Lane's nihilistic singer Corinne 'Third Degree' Burns. The film is shot through with the same punk, DIY aesthetic that powers the story. "We were not normal film people," Lou remembers. "Most of us were first-timers or second-timers. It worked out okay. The film is sort of cult-ish now."

Lou's biggest Hollywood success came as another result of his unerring ability to spot a hit. In 1972 he'd started dating *Get Carter* star Britt Ekland, and the following year she gave birth to their son, Nic. Every few weeks he'd fly to London to visit them. "One day

she called and said: 'You ought to come in early, there's a show everybody's talking about...'" Lou remembers. On a tiny theatre stage, he witnessed a madcap mix of sci-fi, schlocky B-movie horror and '50s rock'n'roll. For Lou and *The Rocky Horror Show*, it was love at first sight. "Can you imagine seeing Tim Curry for the first time?" he says. "I thought he'd be amazing on the big screen. I saw the potential all along. That night I went to a party and met the original producer Michael White and we struck a deal."

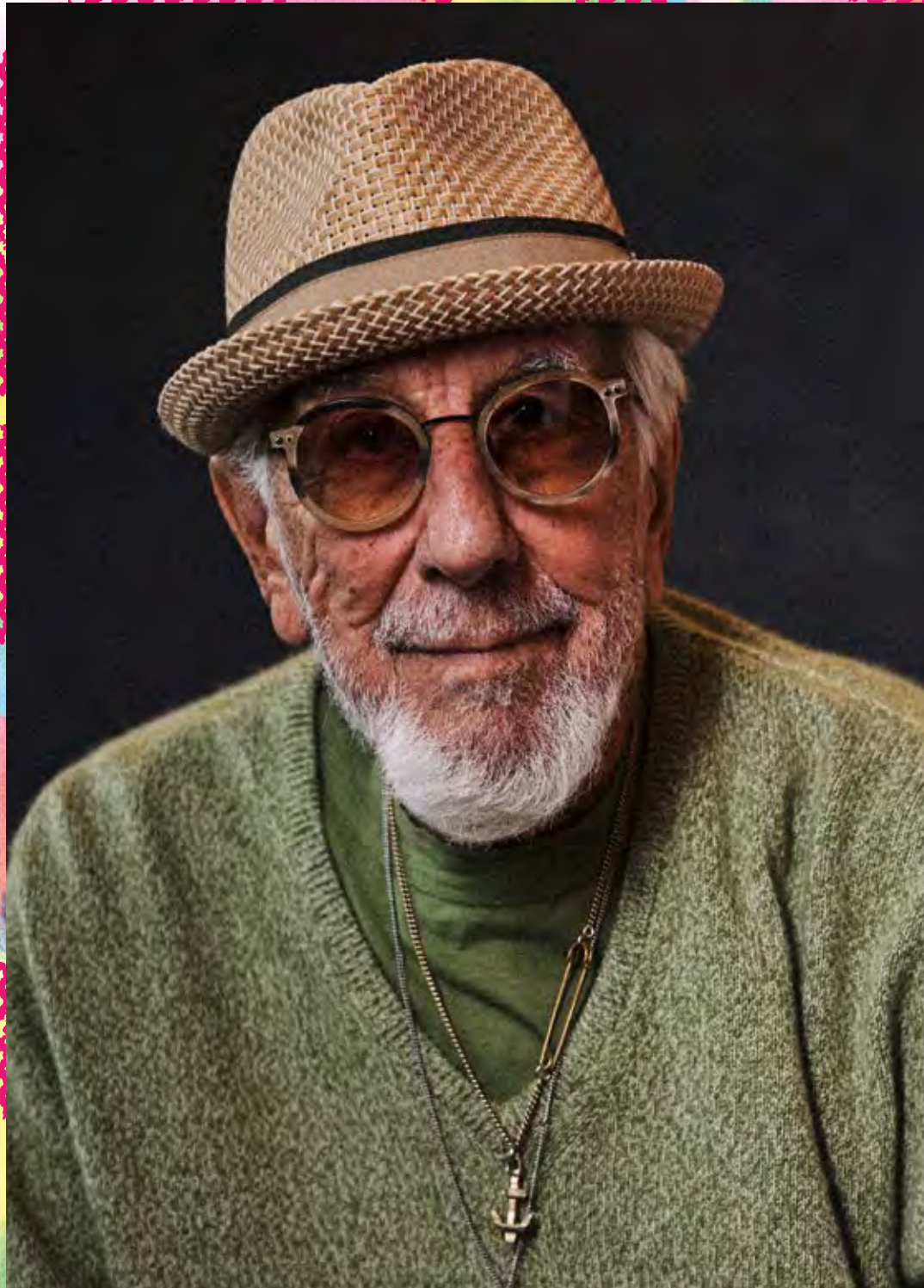
He brought *Rocky Horror* here to The Roxy, where it ran for nine months, and within two years had helped produce the movie *The Rocky Horror Picture Show*. 50 years on, fans new and old are still pulling on their fishnets for screenings. "It's a film that's in distribution more than any other film in the history of film," says Lou, with evident pride. "It plays every weekend, somewhere."

As we've been talking, Lou's two youngest sons, Oscar and Pablo, have snuck into the room to listen in on their dad's larger-than-life stories. He's clearly close to his kids, even with seven to keep track of. When I ask if he has parenting advice, he just smiles and looks at Page. "Yeah," he says. "Get a great mother!"

Lou and Page met at a Lakers basketball game and got married in 1992, when he was 59 and she was 28. He already had three sons and they had four more together. Page says she was more impressed by Lou's parenting than his glittering career. "I picked him because I saw what kind of a father he was," she says. "He put in a lot of time."

They've now been married for over three decades. "I think we just matched up well," says Lou. "I'm obviously much older than her, but she's an old soul. She understands me." The secret to their longevity? "Just love each other, and don't lie," says Lou. Page has a cheekier answer. "Well," she says, "he's a very good kisser."





Lou's decision to focus on his family meant that for many years he considered himself retired from the music industry. Frankly, he didn't need to work, thanks to smart financial moves like keeping hold of his record and film catalogues, investing in property and continuing to run The Roxy as a family business with his eldest sons Nic and Cisco. Recently, though, he's been tempted back into the production booth by his brother-in-law, Neil Young, who married Page's sister in 2018. Lou produced Neil's live album *Before and After* in 2023 and this year was back behind the desk for new record *Talkin to the Trees*. "To work with Neil is just an extension of working with Sam Cooke, Carole King and John Phillips," says Lou. "He's such an intelligent writer. It was a great experience."

We head upstairs so Lou can show me around On The Rox, the Havana-inspired art deco club above The Roxy that for decades has been LA's most exclusive afterparty. "It's all about who you invite," says Lou. "Mostly it was just for me and Jack." That would be Jack Nicholson, Lou's longtime partner-in-crime. In LA there's a running joke about Lou that for all his incredible achievements, what he's best known for is being the guy with the hat and beard sat courtside next to Jack at the Lakers. Lou figures that wouldn't be a bad way to be remembered. "There's another very intelligent, very curious guy," he says about his friend. "That's what makes him a great actor." They first met back when Jack was dating Michelle from The Mamas & The Papas. "We have the same likes and dislikes," says Lou. "We both grew up loving sports. We just connected."

It's almost time for Lou's *Ralph* photoshoot, but first I want to hear what Lou makes of the modern music industry. "Baffling," he says. "It's such a different industry, and that's what it is, an industry. I've gone the gamut. When I started we'd cut the song, I'd go to the pressing plant and press it, and then I'd take the pressing to the radio and talk to a DJ about getting it played that day. Today

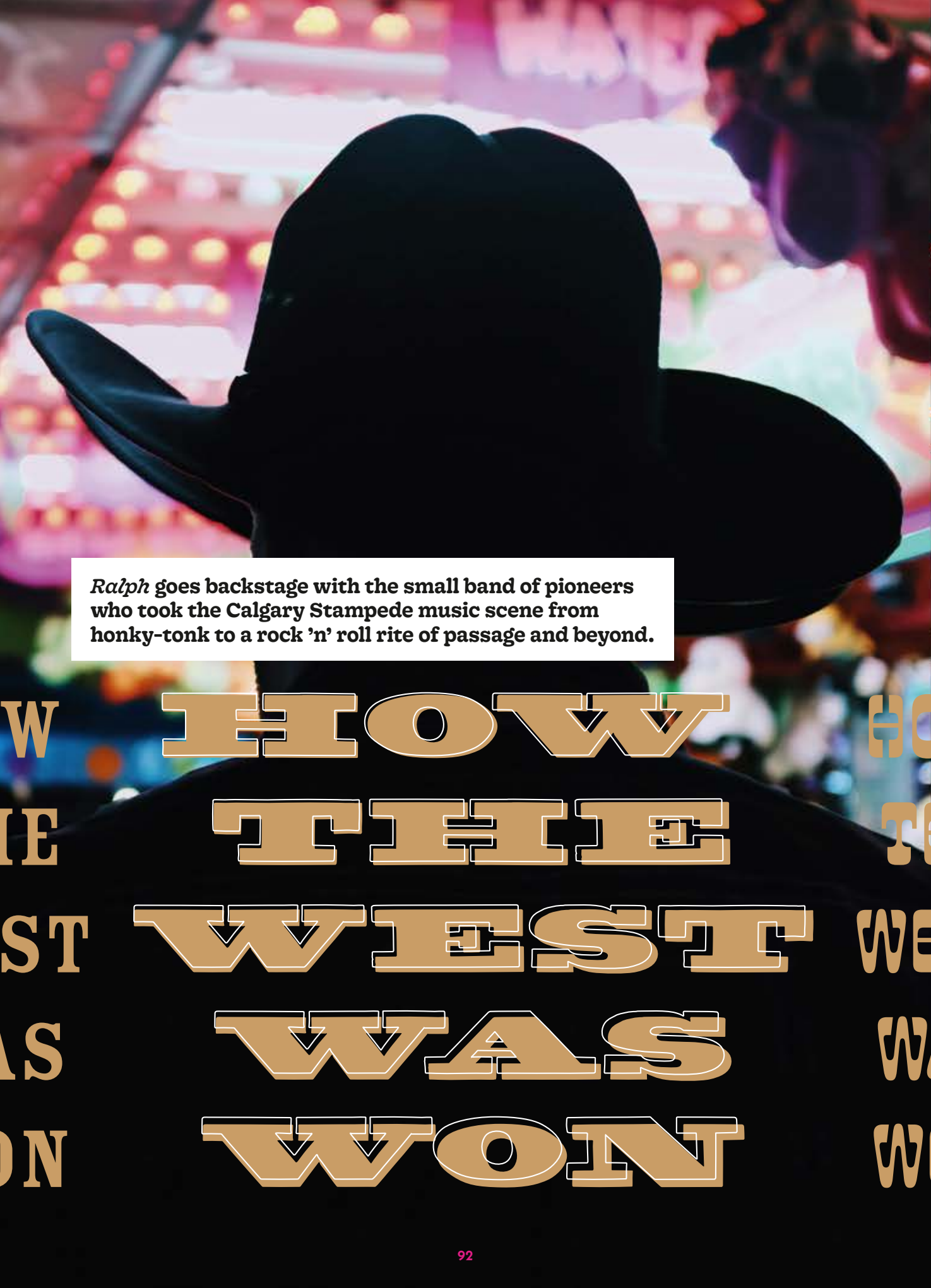
there's so much more exposure of music, which is always good, but I wouldn't know how to compete."

Luckily for Lou, he always had that knack: right place, right time. "The '60s were just amazing," he remembers with a faraway smile. "The music, the new groups, the artists, the writers, all that. It was a cultural revolution stimulated by music and fashion and all of those things coming together. And the drugs, of course. It was an explosion."

From his vantage point, right at the heart of it, did he think he was changing the world? He shakes his head. "You don't feel like: 'Look what we're doing!'" he says, as a sly grin breaks across his face. "Maybe by the time disco came along in the '80s, then you knew you'd done something better than what was happening!" He laughs. "That's when you start to look back to see what you've done."

In 2025, it's clear just how special the work Lou was doing really was. Records like *Tapestry* and *If You Can Believe Your Eyes And Ears* are up there with the greatest of all time. *Up In Smoke*, once dismissed as a juvenile farce, is now preserved in the Library of Congress as a culturally significant work of American art.

Lou says he never worried about his legacy. "I didn't think that way," he says with a shake of his head. "I was just doing whatever came along. I didn't think about how big it would be or how much money it would make. The process was just of so much interest to me that I jumped into it." He's still not quite sure how he ended up being dealt so many winning hands. "It was a lot of luck," he says. "I do have a skill, but nothing that I could train. It just came instinctively." Maybe the secret to living the dream is being smart enough not to wake yourself up. "I never fought it," says Lou with a nod. "I just went with it." *ralph*



Ralph goes backstage with the small band of pioneers who took the Calgary Stampede music scene from honky-tonk to a rock 'n' roll rite of passage and beyond.

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Words by Tracy Kawalik
Photos by The Calgary Stampede



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This isn't my first rodeo – and it sure as hell won't be my last. Ever since I could squeeze into a pair of Laredo boots, the Calgary Stampede in Alberta, Canada has been my stomping ground. Each year the 10-day, 'Greatest Outdoor Show On Earth' draws over 1.5 million guests from every corner of the globe. I watched my dad, Dwight Kawalik, help carve out its music scene alongside a motley crew of the best in the business – true legends of Western hospitality.

So who better to tell its untold history than the pioneers who paved the way – and the crew riding it into the future?

"The Calgary Stampede isn't an attitude—it's a way of life," my dad tells me backstage at Nashville North, the renowned country tent he ran as stage manager for 25 years. As comets of pyrotechnics cascade above, my dad takes off his cowboy hat, inked with a couple of dozen autographs, winks at me and let's out a "Yahoo!" – the stampede call to prayer.

Cowboy hats have long symbolised freedom, hard work, and rugged individualism – and alongside music, those values run deep in the Calgary Stampede's roots. Back in 1912, American cowboy, performer and promoter, Guy Weadick, and his trick roper champion wife, Florence LaDue, rode into Calgary determined to inject the annual fair with Wild West flavour. Wasting no time, Weadick turned his vision into reality, convincing local businessmen Pat Burns, George Lane, A. J. McLean, and A. E. Cross – known as 'The Big Four' – to invest \$25,000 each to stage a lavish downtown parade, and build a rodeo arena where hundreds of cowboys from across Western Canada, the US and Mexico would compete for \$20,000 in prize money. Ever the showman, Weadick urged the whole city to dress Western, deck out their

businesses in 'Wild West' style, and shut downtown for daily street parties with boot-stompin' live music – and they did.

In 1964, Western movie star, and 'King of the Cowboys' Roy Rogers along with Dale Evans played sold-out gigs in Calgary's now demolished Corral arena for all 10 days of that year's Stampede. Then, in 1969, Diana Ross and The Supremes followed the chuckwagon races by headlining the Grandstand Show.

By this time Guy Weadick, Florence LaDue and the Big Four were long gone, but their legacy lived on and the thriving music scene at the Stampede continued to pick up pace. Weadickville, an Old West-style town, was built right on the Stampede grounds and it became a haven for local singer-songwriters, including my good friend's mom, Lesley Schtaz, a rising folk artist.

"In those days, an artist pass meant we could pull our trailer into this little kingdom for 12 days. My kids rode every ride, watched the rodeo close enough to feel the dirt on their faces, and caught every show — though we also shared showers with the bull riders!" Lesley laughs. "I got the gig because I could tear it up on the banjo. I was a songwriter with a few tracks like 'Alberta Waltz' on the radio, and I'd even recorded in Nashville. Eventually, I was hired for Capital Country Television — a Stampede-only show where the most famous names in Canadian country music would stop by to record a song, with me and another girl on harmonies and backup."

One of the wildest additions was The Beach in 1991 – an 'oasis' built from tons of trucked-in tons, faux palm trees and a stage where '60's surf bands rocked out.

Enter, Dwight, my dad. From age 13, he'd cut his teeth in the music business, designing posters and badges for bands and working as a roadie at weekends. Now, three

"The Calgary Stampede isn't an attitude – it's a way of life"

Dwight Kawalik



Don Toliver



decades later, one of those bands, called Fun Company, were the local headliners at The Beach. That summer, he went from roadie to unofficial stage manager, while also catching the attention of the people running the Coca-Cola Stage – a burgeoning DIY spot surrounded by green grass and towering trees, that was getting more and more popular every year.

It's here he joined Clarke Smith, a former spotlight operator turned stage manager. "The music at Coca-Cola Stage was a combination of theatrics. We had amazing tribute bands like '60s Mania from Australia who had 10+ costume and wig changes to Terry Stokes, a hypnotist who'd performed in Vegas," Dwight recalls.

Back then, the band equipment was hauled by hand 500 feet along a dirt track, using a red trolley they had to padlock to the stage steps so it wouldn't get stolen. Then each piece of kit, with no ramp, was lifted up onto the 6ft stage overhead. In 1999, my dad and Clarke were joined by JT, a multi-talented lighting and sound contractor. He gave the Coca-Cola Stage a significant and major upgrade to the bass amp, lighting, fresh mics and a red Pearl 14-piece drum kit that looked like it had been stolen straight out of a rock star's fever dream.

Together, the trio's magic worked – in the years that followed, artists like Nelly Furtado, Nickleback, Kid Rock, Chubby Checker and Sheryl Crow ignited the Coca-Cola Stage. I was lucky enough to be perched on a stool to the side during many of those seminal gigs – wrapping cables, cutting gels for lights, and watching my dad work through thunderstorms and heatwaves. Often I was alongside another curious young girl and talented protégé, Jodie Walsh, Clarke's daughter, who, following her father's retirement, has taken over his role. "The Coca-Cola stage has been in our family since 1984." Jodie explains. "I remember coming to help my dad one summer when I

was 14 and absolutely falling in love with it. He taught me the ropes, from the front of house stuff to the back and on stage," she beams proudly.

The stage had a spell-binding magic from every angle – but the rarest sight of all was tucked away beneath it, in the dressing rooms. "There were so many intimate, memorable moments hanging out with artists in that tiny space," Jodie reflects. "Whether it was huddling together when the power went out during an electrical storm or figuring out how to boil an egg in a kettle for Sheryl Crow, everyone became fast friends and felt like part of a family."

One of the gnarliest gigs in the stage's history came courtesy of Canadian alt-rockers Rhymes with Orange. "They had a rowdy crowd. At one point, someone kicked off the sprinkler head at the front of the stage, and suddenly we had a 12-foot water jet in the middle of the mosh pit that became a mud pit. Over the next few days, the whole field of grass started to rot." JT recalls.

In 1998, Dwight was tasked with taking over Nashville North – a country stage with a lot of potential in need of a stage manager. Clarke stayed to manage the Coca-Cola stage and he, along with Dwight and JT started garnering the respect as the sort of Eavises *[the family who run Glastonbury festival in the UK]* of The Calgary Stampede.

The concept behind Nashville North was to recreate the iconic country music venue, the Grand Ole Opry in actual Nashville – decorated with a Western façade, giant wagon wheel chandeliers with flickering candles, and a 20-foot neon Budweiser Flying-V guitar hanging over a parquet dance floor packed with line dancers.

"When I got there, it was a shit hole!" Dwight laughs. "It wasn't organised – no dressing rooms, safety issues, sound all over the place. Everything needed repairing or replacing."

On top of that, the tent stunk. An asphalt border was poured around the wooden floor to 'secure' it – but instead, booze had pooled underneath. By the end of the run, when they finally lifted the floor, the liquid was apparently acid green.

But Dwight and the new crew transformed Nashville North into the hottest joint on the Calgary Stampede grounds, by improving the sound and the lighting, all the way through to constructing the dressing rooms backstage. They hosted the Dixie Chicks and the Nitty Gritty Dirt Band, wheeled in a white baby grand piano for Diamond Rio, and Lukas Nelson – son of Willie Nelson – needed help yanking splinters out of his feet after he insisted on dancing barefoot on the beat-up wooden stage. "I remember in the late '90s, Kiefer Sutherland and Lou Diamond Phillips came by and started flying through the crowd with their arms outstretched, chasing each other on the dance floor," Dwight laughs.

"Everyone's favourite band was Kentucky Headhunters," JT adds. "Out of all the acts we worked with, those guys ticked every box – they gave an excellent performance that rattled the whole tent, their management was easy to deal with, their road crew was a dream, and they were just nice guys."

In 2008, Jason Tate – aka Big Jay – was brought in as official MC and host. A DJ was added, and by 2010, JT joined Dwight as co-stage manager. They shared everything 50/50, right down to the cash, trailers they crashed in backstage for the entire duration and the work it took to build the hype. Each summer, punters queued five hours or more to get into Nashville North, with celebrities like Penélope Cruz, Steven Seagal and Kevin Costner pulling up backstage.

It wasn't all about celebrity though. Dwight remembers, "One of the best gigs we ever had was Western Heritage Day, where what you'd call 'blue hairs' – real old-school folks – would come down to hear cowboy poetry

and classic country singers. As the Stampede steps further into the big festival boots it's growing into, I hope that true Western spirit lasts forever."

A prime example of that spirit came in 2013, when just 20 days before opening night, downtown Calgary was completely underwater in some of the worst floods the state of Alberta had seen. "I honestly didn't think the Stampede would happen that year," my father says. "But the way the community rallied was unbelievable. I remember turning on the news and seeing 1,000 volunteers at Stampede Park in 'Hell or High Water' T-shirts, and hundreds more cleaning nearby streets after the flood to make sure the show went on."

"If you asked me my proudest moment from 25 years as stage manager, it's as much about being part of once-in-a-lifetime shows as it is walking away with once-in-a-lifetime friendships," Dwight says.

JT remembers what made his friend and colleague Dwight a successful stage manager: "It was his attention to detail – always going the extra mile. He knew that when an artist arrived, they'd want towels and water. He knew what they drank, what cigars they smoked etc." But he reflects, "Year by year, we could feel things were moving in a different direction. I remember walking into the tent two days before the Stampede and they hadn't put the wagon wheel chandeliers up in Nashville. I looked at Dwight and I said, 'it's the beginning of the end.'"

The following Stampede, in 2017, Dwight and JT were called to a Starbucks, handed a belt buckle as commiseration, and told the show was over – they were being swapped out for a new in-house team.

I was heartbroken. Guilty, even, that I hadn't stepped up like Jodie did for her dad. But they were both ready to pass the torch on.

Those guys didn't just ignite my passion for the live music industry – they taught me three things: be grateful for every person who keeps the show running, know how to throw one hell of a party, and, maybe most importantly, know when to leave.

"I was there for so long that sometimes, while I was working, I missed the magical moments," JT admits. "Every once in a while, since we've stepped back, I catch myself watching something, and thinking, 'fuck, this is cool'. We were a part of this and I just hope Stampede goes on forever."

Fast forward to 2025, and the music at Stampede is now big business – Nashville North has exploded from a 1500-capacity 'honkeytonk' to a 6000-capacity country club with a stage 10 times the size of the original. Now astroturf covers the sprawling backstage area of sparkling artist trailers for TikTok famous, number-one-selling country performers with millions of fans.

Beyond the Ferris wheel and the barns where hundred-thousand-dollar bulls and prize-winning bucking broncos sleep, the thunder of a traditional Indigenous pow wow fades under the moon – someone pulls the trigger on \$1 million worth of fireworks, and sets the midnight sky ablaze – every single night of Stampede.

This year drones etched a gold eagle overhead while Texan rapper Don Toliver commanded a sea of teens in Stetsons in the afterglow of a Diplo set. Across the Stampede grounds, Lil Jon and De La Soul packed out a dance floor of hip-hop heads while Shania Twain headlined a sold-out show in a saddle-shaped dome – with some tickets going for \$1,000 apiece.

The original Coca-Cola Stage broke new acts like Sabrina Carpenter, Carly Rae Jepsen, Orville Peck, and King Princess before the heaving crowds and hype transformed the tiny setup into a jaw-dropping production

that could rival the main stages of Coachella. Today, the Coca-Cola Stage is located in the heart of the park, complete with a specialised black-and-white Marley dance floor, towering LED video walls boasting the highest pixel density in Western Canada, and a parking spot that lorries packed with gear can drive right up to.

Taylor Swift, Usher, The Roots, Pitbull, The Beach Boys, and Bon Jovi have all stormed the soon-to-be-demolished Saddledome and Lil Yachty, Tinashe, Killer Mike, TLC, Benson Boone, and even Pauly D from Jersey Shore are among the artists who have played nearby stages.

"Change is good. But Nashville North doesn't exist without the history and foundation it was built on," says Big Jay, who as MC is the tent's heartbeat, bringing it to life each night. "It generated and garnered all that because of the sweat and tears of your dad, JT and others," he continues.

Today, Jodie's wrangled the whole family to run the stage alongside industry pros. Respecting the importance of Western hospitality amid the evolution, she shares, "My dad used to walk the crowds with me when I first started, and I still love doing that now. For some kids, this is their first concert. To look back and see thousands of smiling people dancing, having the time of their lives – that feels amazing. That's the reminder of what it's all about."

"The Calgary Stampede is a rite of passage for Calgarians," Big Jay adds. "You can see it in the eyes of kids who've just become adults, and artists playing their first shows on those stages who are about to blow up."

The Calgary Stampede has a big economic impact, generating nearly \$300 million for the city each year. As a result, tents with 5000+ capacity have sprung up citywide, hosting adjacent events. Such as The Cowboys Music Festival, which has featured



Chase Rice



Koe Wetzel



De La Soul



Dwight Kowalik



Tinashe

Lil Nas X, and The Badlands Music Festival, which has welcomed world class acts like Tiësto, FISHER and enigmatic masked DJ Horsegirl.

All of this attracts a host of international influencers, styled to the nines in rhinestones and fringes. The city welcomes Ru Paul's Drag Race stars, 'Cowboy Carter' themed nights and Chappelle Roan tribute acts. Last summer, Drake was even spotted cooling off and keeping a low profile during Stampede after his Kendrick beef.

As for the future of the music at 'The Greatest Outdoor Show On Earth', this year Weadickville was knocked down to make room for a luxury hotel. "It's not the same, it can't be, nothing is. But the new changes are exciting and I personally love them. You have to embrace it," Dwight says. "It's big business now, the whole world is watching and coming to town for it. If it becomes one of the greatest music festivals of the future with rap, techno, rock, you name it, my only hope is they fill it with people who know about the roots, love the rodeo and keep it Western." *ralph*

DISPATCH #5 - PUNTA PRIMA

MENORCA, SPAIN



Ralph's Food & Drink Editor and global sandwich pioneer, Max Halley, reports from the corners of his gastronomic globe



*"Hell is other people."
Jean-Paul Sartre*

The three of us sat completely still, transfixed by the bird and its extraordinary head-feathers. They quivered and danced as it hopped and bounced across the immaculate grass, looking for food and watching for danger. "Wow!" My daughter Coco (20 months) said, mimicking the bird's bobbing head with her own.

I knew it was a hoopoe, wisest of all, from reading Attar of Nishapur's seminal poem *The Conference of the Birds*, but this was the first time I'd actually seen one. As we were also on my first (in this case, not quite) all-inclusive holiday, this was revving up to be quite a week.

I say 'not quite' because the price included breakfast and one other meal a day, but we still had to pay for our drinks and the other meal if we had it in situ, rather than in the world outside. This seemed like a great idea when we booked (and still does now) because Punta Prima, with its beach and shops and restaurants and things, was clearly a lovely town, right next to and not that much bigger than, our sprawling hotel complex.

After we had checked in and been shown to our spotless, light filled, super-king-bedded apartment, we unpacked our bags, slumped on the loungers outside and that was when we saw the hoopoe. Carried away in the moment and by the bird and things, I said to my wife Magali and Coco, "You know what guys? If I could be anywhere in world right now, I'd be right here with you two." "Wow!" Coco said again, pointing at a small lizard dashing across the path in front of us seeking the shelter of a neatly trimmed shrub of some kind. "Come on," Magali said, "let's go for a swim!" Something which as a fat man, I always slightly dread. After reading a confusing note in the bathroom about towels, we headed to the pool with Coco

clutching her tiny inflatable boat. It was about 11am, the pool was massive, and a beautiful shimmering blue. The water was high and inviting and the view of the sea extraordinary. There was an island a mile or so out with a lighthouse on it and a huge nature reserve.

We splashed about in the pool for a bit, extremely fortunate to have its vastness briefly to ourselves. A big English family began to appear – Granny and Grandpa, their children and their children's children and so on. Soon everything was very loud and there was a frisson of competition and aggression in the air. A boy of about six ran and jumped, landing in the vast expanse of empty pool, only a foot from Coco and momentarily upsetting her apple cart. Granny stood up, clenched her fists in the air, looked me dead in the eye and shouted "YEEEEAAHHHH!!! GO ON HARRY!!!" I imagined myself drowning her in the pool but stayed silent and we moved around to another side. Understandably buoyed by his nan's continuing encouragement, Harry jumped again and again, inching ever closer. We got out and the pool was all theirs, to the victor the spoils.

Other families arrived and soon it just wasn't possible for anyone to dominate the space. Wind in sails fizzled away and a peaceful equilibrium was reached. Magali and I had a Piña Colada while Coco played next to us, and we were all happy and relaxed and everything was dinky doo. We even saw another hoopoe, albeit this time pecking at some chips by a recently vacated lounger. As my mum, greatest of all the metaphor mixers would have said: "There's no ointment in paradise."

We headed into town and bee-lined for a beachfront restaurant called *Aire* that a friend had recommended. Amongst the spaghetti bolognese, bangers and mash and other fresh-out-the-freezer tourist stuff I'm sure they're obliged to sell, there was gold

"SMASH! A table was dive bombed violently by an enormous sea gull. One of the waitresses whipped a water pistol from beneath her apron and fired it until the giant bird flapped off"





to be found. We ordered tapas portions of grilled cuttlefish, little fried squids and fresh anchovies. We had the tenderest steamed mussels, pieces of Iberico pork cooked over fire (rare if insisted on), some of the best grilled prawns ever and a bottle of delicious Menorcan white wine. God bless Spain and its culinary ideals. Lemon wedges and aioli were brought without asking and there was olive oil and sherry vinegar on every table. We were in heaven. Such heaven in fact, we returned five out of the following six days, Coco working her way through a bowl of mussels every time. After lunch we went to the beach for a swim and headed back to the hotel for a lie down and to gather ourselves before dinner at the buffet restaurant.

Having never done anything like this before I was overwhelmed, or at least whelmed, by the plethora of stuff to choose from. There was EVERYTHING, from meatballs and moussaka to barbecue ribs and potato smileys. Little pieces of fish and meat you could get grilled, a kind of deli section with anchovies and salamis and stuff – literally hundreds of things. The diamonds in the rough weren't perhaps as polished as those at Aire, but they were there. The charcuterie was fantastic and I assembled some really good pan con tomate using the toaster, a garlic clove I found garnishing something and some decent tomatoes. We were given a free glass of cava by a hilarious and gregarious waiter when we sat down with our food and despite being cracked, my glass was more than half full. Two people on another table outside had apparently gone back in to get something when SMASH! Their table was dive bombed violently by an enormous sea gull. One of the waitresses whipped a water pistol from beneath her apron and fired it until the giant bird flapped off knocking cutlery, two wine glasses and a plate on the floor. It landed nearby on the grass and, barring the livid people whose supper it had stolen, and who pleasingly turned out to be (you guessed it) Harry's grandparents,

the whole terrace watched it gulp down an entire, on-the-bone, massive sticky BBQ pork rib. All in one go. We were all somehow bonded by this moment and still laughing and chatting about it at breakfast the next day. The staff were kind and attentive and fun. A swift way to any parent's heart is to be kind to their children and these guys knocked it out the park. Over our stay, many of them remembered Coco's name and brought her things and were just wonderful (thank you Jess!) and it was charm personified.

There was lots to do at the hotel and in the town. We had massages, took Coco to the water park, attempted and quickly abandoned an ill-advised kayak trip to the lighthouse, came across an enormous rhinoceros beetle on the way to do some washing, took the bus into Mahón, the island's capital (allegedly the home of mayonnaise – or what they claim was originally called Mahónnaise) and loads of other stuff that fitted easily between lunch and dinner.

When Sartre said "hell is other people" he didn't mean it that simply. He meant that as so many of our perceptions, freedoms and feelings are affected and even dominated by those of other people, it is easy to become trapped (sometimes hellishly so) by what others do and think and to forget to be free and enjoy ourselves. And here, on the southern coast of Menorca, despite the hotel's food not being great and Harry's pool bombing etc., there was joy and kindness everywhere, at the hotel and in Punta Prima. Even those awkward bits only drove home the things that really matter: being with your family, not getting caught up in your own bullshit and remembering to cream the buffet of life for all its worth. I mean seriously, when your daughter's smiling, you're married to someone you love, you've seen your first hoopoe and you haven't gone to prison for drowning someone who didn't deserve it, how bad can life really be? *ralph*



SUKEBAN SUKEBAN SUKEBAN

WWW



Meet Japan's wildest travelling wrestler queens.

Words by Gemma Lacey
Photos by Morgan Maher

Anime Expo's most anticipated event wasn't a panel, a cosplay contest, or even a K-pop cameo—it was a grudge match with a difference. Imagine latex-clad girl gangs from Tokyo strutting into the ring via wind-up toy boxes, wielding dollies like weapons and hurling each other across the mat under a blitz of strobes. Hair-pulling meets acrobatics. Choreographed chaos. A DJ scratches vinyl in the corner. It's theatre, it's spectacle, it's sport—and it's called Sukeban.

Welcome to the world dreamed up by cult designer Olympia Le-Tan (yes, the embroidered book clutch one). Sukeban isn't your standard ring-side affair. Think less WWE and more Harajuku-meets-Warriors with an art-school edge. It's chaos, couture and choreographed combat.

It all started when Olympia's brother-in-law, Alex (Detrick formerly of Supreme), was helping New Japan Pro Wrestling expand into the US, and spotted the potential of Japan's female fighters. He roped in Olympia to do the costumes. "I had to be begged," she laughs, "but I said yes, on the condition that it had to be cool."

Cool, it turns out, is a massive understatement.

Sukeban takes its name from the '70s Japanese delinquent girl gangs. The vibe? Less brawler, more beautifully stylised badass. Olympia and team hand-picked their roster of fighters from Japan, each with her own colour, style and energy—from Bingo, the electric fan-favourite, to Atomic Banshee, the Vivienne Westwood obsessive with proper punk spirit.

"In Japan, the girls were wearing metallic bikinis and strappy lycra. That wasn't the direction I wanted," says Olympia. Instead, she went for latex. It's louder, sexier and

weirdly poetic when it slaps against the mat. It also photographs like a dream.

Latex might be tricky to sew, but it has bite – and in Olympia's hands, it becomes a glossy armour for rebellion. With help from London's Soft Skin Latex and other collaborators, each wrestler got a custom piece. No two bodies the same, no templates, no fit models. "They're athletes," Olympia says. "Built by movement."

But it's not just the clothes. Sukeban is a whole world. Before each match, wrestlers are introduced with glossy character cards like Top Trumps for fashion nerds. There are girl gangs from different Tokyo districts: the Harajuku crew, the Ginza gang, the Shibuya squad. Each one draws from real Japanese subcultures—decora, sukajan jackets, school uniforms and streetwear all remixed with attitude.

"We were really inspired by *The Warriors*," Olympia explains, referencing the cult 1979 film about New York gangs in themed outfits. "But our version is kawaii meets chaos."

It wouldn't be a proper Olympia production without impeccable glam. Makeup has been handled by legends like Pat McGrath, nail art by the iconic Nails by Mei. Past shows featured full latex looks, Westwood references, and Harajuku dream-girl kitsch.

"Makeup in wrestling is usually DIY," Olympia says. "I thought, what if we had Pat McGrath do it? That would change everything."

And it did. Suddenly, these weren't just fighters. They were supernovas—equal parts superhero, fashion muse and chaotic good.

Sukeban is a love letter to Joshi Pro Wrestling, the all-female Japanese genre that boomed in the '80s and '90s. Back then, the wrestlers were idols – beloved by teenage girls and pop-culture obsessives. Today,



“In a time where so many rights are being rolled back, this feels like something defiant. Something joyful”

most of the Japanese wrestling audience are middle-aged men. Sukeban wants to flip that script.

“It used to be that girls had posters of these wrestlers in their bedrooms,” Olympia says. “They were stars – fighters, singers, gymnasts. That’s what we want to bring back.”

To help, they brought on Bull Nakano – the most legendary villain in ‘90s Joshi Pro Wrestling – as commissioner. She helps scout talent and keeps the vibe legit.

Don’t be fooled into thinking this is all niche fandom. Sukeban has teamed up with TikTok, pulled in K-pop newcomers, and even featured a Yo-Yo champion mid-show. It’s giving *Gem and the Holograms* meets *RuPaul’s Drag Race* via *Kill Bill*. The crowd? Equal parts fashion kids, culture editors, and six-year-olds screaming for Bingo.

Olympia has dreams of developing it into an anime and fashion line, with wearable looks

inspired by the wrestlers. “We want to do a proper show in Tokyo and New York,” she says. “And a Harajuku shop, definitely.”

The team is planning to open auditions for the next round of fighters. Not just wrestlers, but dancers, gymnasts, martial artists—anyone with attitude.

“It’s definitely a rebellion,” Olympia nods. “In a time when so many rights are being rolled back, this feels like something defiant. Something joyful.” She’s not wrong. In an age of bleak news cycles and burnout, Sukeban is a fizzy, unfiltered jolt of girl-powered joy. And if you can’t make it to a show, keep an eye out—the merch drops are limited and cultish, and you just know Bingo’s face on a Sukajan jacket is going to sell out in seconds.

This isn’t just wrestling. It’s world-building. It’s fashion. It’s feral. It’s fabulous. And in the words of Commander Nakajima? You’d better watch your back.

Here’s the Ralph guide to the core of the Sukeban Universe. Choose your player.



ATOMIC BANSHEE

Style: Riot Couture
Signature Move: The Rainmaker
Vibe: Vivienne Westwood meets street brawler
Faction: The Vandals



DELIRIOUS DOLLY

Style: Babydoll Dresses
Signature Move: The Dolly Smack
Vibe: Courtney Love meets Chucky
Faction: Tokyo Toys



SAKI BIMI

Style: Turned Up Takishimi
Signature Move: Kawildbuster
Vibe: Cute but deadly
Faction: Harajuku Stars



ICHIGO SAYAKA

Style: Sailor Moon on steroids
Signature Move: Strawberry Bomb
Vibe: Playful
Faction: Harajuku Stars



COMMANDER NAKAJIMA

Style: Alexander McQueen
meets Robert Smith

Signature Move: The Cutie Special

Vibe: Menacing

Faction: Dangerous Liaisons



COUNTESS REA SATO

Style: French Revolutionary

Signature Move: The Beret Breakdown

Vibe: Off with their heads

Faction: Dangerous Liaisons



SAREE BOMB

Style: Harley Quinn Harajuku

Signature Move: Muta Lock

Vibe: Midnight Player

Faction: Cherrybomb Girls



STRAY CAT

Style: Shiny, black and chic

Signature Move: One Hit Kill

Vibe: Claws Out

Faction: Unaffiliated



CRUSH YUU

Style: Sukajan meets Streetwear

Signature Move: Last Ride

Vibe: Deceptively cute

Faction: Cherrybomb Girls



VICTORIA YUZUKI

Style: Pretty tough

Signature Move: The Victory Vault

Vibe: Gorgeous but vicious

Faction: Dangerous Liaisons



QUEEN OF HEARTS

Style: Vivienne Westwood
meets Alice in Wonderland

Signature Move: Diving Leg Drop

Vibe: Regal

Faction: Dangerous Liaisons



BABYFACE

Style: Sassy Sailor

Signature Move: Flying Armbar

Vibe: Sweet but sneaky

Faction: Harajuka Stars

A Love Letter To:

Toni Collette

At the Ralph office, if someone proclaims they're Toni Collette's biggest fan and could easily write a piece about why she's so amazing, we'll say, "go on then, prove it."

Words by Jess Wallace
Illustration by James-Lee Duffy



From my extensive market research of the general public over the past six years, it seems there is a significant knowledge gap in the magic of Toni Collette, which I find frankly unacceptable - and I have made it my mission to right that wrong. It's time she got her flowers for the roles that allow her to showcase that she truly is one of the most talented actresses working today. Although some of her more mainstream roles will be covered, my love for her lies deeper in her filmography, and what's a love letter without proving that you know someone's entire career to a questionable extent.

Like 50% of Australia's most successful actors (the other 50% having starred in iconic TV show *Neighbours*), Toni Collette attended the National Institute of Dramatic Art (NIDA) but dropped out after 18 months to kickstart her career in the Sydney Theatre Company's 1992 production of Anton Chekhov's play *Uncle Vanya*. But it wasn't until two years later, that the words TONI COLLETTE lit up the world's stage, in her breakout role in *Muriel's Wedding* (1994).

When you look at her terrifyingly solemn performance in *Hereditary* (2018), it's hard to imagine her beginnings as the rural Australian, ABBA loving, disaster that is Muriel Hislop. She doesn't know how to flirt, or how to be in love, but she wants, above all else, to be married - something that will mean she has truly changed from the Muriel she once was. Toni brings so many emotional layers to the role, but what really makes her shine is the physicality she brings to the character. Her insane giggle, inappropriate flirting, and extravagant breakdown in a bridal shop, are so well and intentionally crafted, that none of these expressions make her feel like a caricature. The borderline slapstick performance doesn't make you laugh, instead you end up cringing, and

reconsidering your own behaviour as a young adult, as you sympathise with Muriel, despite her actions.

Her ability to embody second hand embarrassment is only amplified in her portrayal of Harriet Smith in Jane Austen's *Emma* (1996). Although comparison is the thief of joy, it works in Collette's favour here, as, compared to all the other *Emma* adaptations that have made it to the screen, this Harriet is the only one who steals the show from the titular character. She's giggly and awkward, giving off the girlish charm that you would expect would need to be thwarted, and as a viewer you can't help but feel for her when she does, in fact, end up thwarted. Making you empathise with a character is a very powerful tool in Collette's wheelhouse of talent - but an even more potent one is making you feel absolute disdain towards her character.

One of the main reasons Collette has the status she does in Hollywood, yet seemingly slipping under the awards' radar (looking at you Oscars), might be because of how seamlessly she transforms into some absolute wackadoodle characters. My favourite instance of this is *Velvet Buzzsaw* (2019), where Collette played an art curator called Gretchen, and managed to accomplish something she has never done before: she made me hate her. Maybe it was the bob wig, or Collette's ability to truly embody her characters and their motives, but you simply cannot stand the bitch. Gretchen is morally corrupt, selfish, and frankly, annoying, yet when her character shares these same traits in *Mickey 17* (2025), she makes them work. It seems that Collette is aware of these nuances. Even when characters share similar attributes, she manages to make one (in Gen Z terms) a 'diva', and the other a heinous megalomaniac. Whether it's a subtle look to camera, or background reactions, her holistic and careful approach to character work manages to completely erase the woman behind the wig, making for some unrecognisable transformations.

jen's
Muriel Hislop
Sheryl Hoover
Milley & Julie



In the Charlie Kaufman directed *I'm Thinking Of Ending Things* (2020), Collette's acting power – in my opinion – is at full capacity. She simultaneously makes you feel pity and annoyance for her character, while remaining totally compelling. For this film, she graduates from her own school of acting, taking the over the top giggles from *Muriel's Wedding*, the helplessness from *Emma* and the bonkers nature of *Mickey 17*, combining them to create one of my all time favourite performances of hers. Playing multiple version of one character is child's play for Collette at this point in her career, but in *I'm Thinking Of Ending Things* she goes from 0-100 in the blink of an eye. From sitting meekly at the dinner table being berated by her son, to suddenly cutting to being a cheerful '50s housewife, she continues to weave a consistent thread of melancholy throughout all versions of her character. It doesn't matter what words are coming out of her mouth, Collette has such an intimate understanding of who her character is, even if her purpose is to be a pawn in someone else's character growth.

Collette has a consistent ability to be nuanced in her characters, most notably as Julie in comedy/drama *Cosi* (1996) and Sheryl in the critically acclaimed *Little Miss Sunshine* (2006). Julie is introduced as an archetypal overly negative, depressed young drug addict, a trope that often feels frustrating in other films. But not Julie. Collette manages to create a nuance in her character that makes her feel grounded and approachable. She's humble, smart, and outspoken on feminist issues, without letting herself become the stereotype that misogynists love to hate. With so few scenes to sell her character, she still does so effortlessly, knowing when to dial it up or down. In *Little Miss Sunshine*, she plays the mother of aspiring beauty pageant contestant Olive and mute teenage son Dwayne. Most of her familial relationships are filled with love, but are not necessarily amicable. She spends a lot of her scenes in the background,

with no leading storyline or character arc to focus on – but this is where Collette's acting skills really shine. For example, in one scene, where she's in the car, simply listening to the conversation happening around her. A lot of actors would just sit back and watch, knowing that the camera is not focused on them, but not Collette. She takes care not only to react to what is being said, but also takes on other minor tasks, checking the backseat, the rearview mirror, all alongside reacting to the conversation – she takes the time to really make her character feel real. Taking on the role of a mum is probably what she is best known for, and is ultimately what has bequeathed her the Gen Z title of: Mother.

Collette plays Milly – a mother diagnosed with breast cancer – in *Miss You Already* (2015), who has such a special place in my heart, it would be a dishonour not to mention her. Milly feels so real – like you could just pick her out of the screen and plop her into a Walthamstow café, wrangling her kids to finish their hot chocolate. With such a sensitive and emotional topic as cancer, a huge part of Collette's commitment to the role is what made Milly come to life, actually shaving her head for the film.

From a glance at her career, Toni Collette is a successful and celebrated actress, *Knives Out* (2019) and *Hereditary* took the mainstream by storm and no one is happier for that than I. As we go deeper into her filmography, it's clear why she is so successful, and it's time the world sang as loudly about her acting as I have been. She is a genius at character work, taking time to understand her characters to their fullest potential, even if it is just a supporting role. She is nuanced in her performances, building out a past, present and future for all the people she embodies, as if each film is just a glimpse into their ongoing lives. This was just a glimpse into Collette's ongoing career, and I can't wait to see what she does next.

I love you, Toni Collette. *ralph*

DON'T GOOGLE THIS

Things we heard that might be true

Illustrations by Rin @ylc_illustration



Roger Moore (James Bond actor) invented the Magnum ice-cream after complaining about choc ices needing sticks.



Roman statues used to be painted in bright colours



The CIA once ran a Star Wars fan site to act as a hidden messaging platform for undercover agents



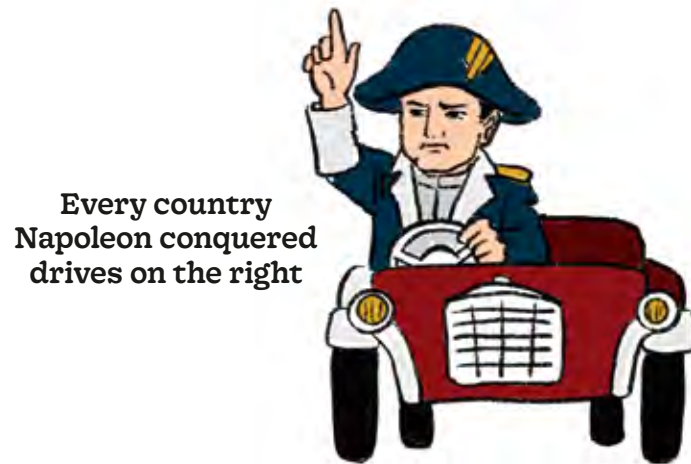
The width of a Roman chariot's axel determined the maximum diameter of early space rockets



404 error means you need to go to room 404 at Cerne to physically rectify the problem



POSH means port out starboard home - where rich peoples' cabins were situation on boats



Every country Napoleon conquered drives on the right



The French only abolished the use of the Guillotine in 1981



Baby owls sleep face down on their stomachs because their heads are so heavy



Nobody knows what gravity is



The wings of a cockroach and the tail of a shrimp are made from the same thing

POPCORN PIRATE

We asked our mystery reviewer what they think of the new power ups on *Mario Kart World* on the Switch 2

I'm a child of the N64, a simpler time when *Mario Kart* came with real risks and power ups that read like a vegan cheesecake recipe (red, green, spiky shells, mushrooms, bananas, stars, lightning and ghosts). Aka the good old days. Cut to the present day, and *Mario Kart World* on the Switch 2. It's a smoother drive with better graphics, but Rainbow Road has all the thrill of a bowling lane with the gutter bars up. Not to sound like a curmudgeonly Gen Xer, but adding a zillion characters (who the hippy hell is Para-Biddybud?) and earning coins for new cars isn't my jam. I miss the MySpace style top 8, where we were loyal to our chosen driver. Your Mario Kart character was a personality trait (Bowser, don't @ me).

Anyway, I don't know why I'm moaning because when *Ralph* asked me to review the new Mario Kart power ups they handed me perhaps the best assignment anyone has ever had. Let'sa go!



Mega Mushroom

This makes up for how shit the thunderbolt in this version is (they're tiny for one second and no one gets hurt – so lame!) Mega mushroom makes you big and you can squash people. Delicious!



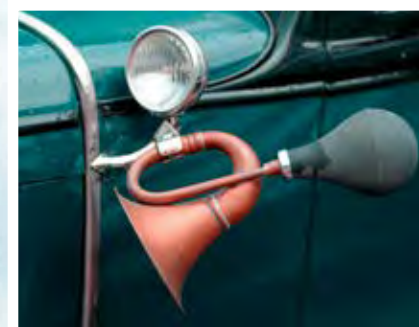
Magic Bullet

Turn into a massive bullet and get ridden round the course like a strap on. Babes, if you're getting this in your power box it's because you're bottom. Love it.



Feather

Man what?! If you time it really, really well you can MAYBE avoid getting wonked by an incoming weapon. I imagine in that very specific set of events, using the feather to foil a blue shell would be tasty AF, but I played for 17 hours and never got the chance to do this.



Super Horn

Releases a klaxon thing that jangles nearby drivers, but they need to be like an Audi (right up your arse) to make any difference. I like the concept, but I've never seen it effectively used for or against me.



Throwing Hammers

Sends three chunky black hammers into the road in front of you, looks good, does fuck all. Wait, is this a me problem?



Ice Flower

More useful for a bartender than a driver, chuck balls of ice around and 'freeze' someone for a fraction of a second, which doesn't really slow them down. Uninspired.

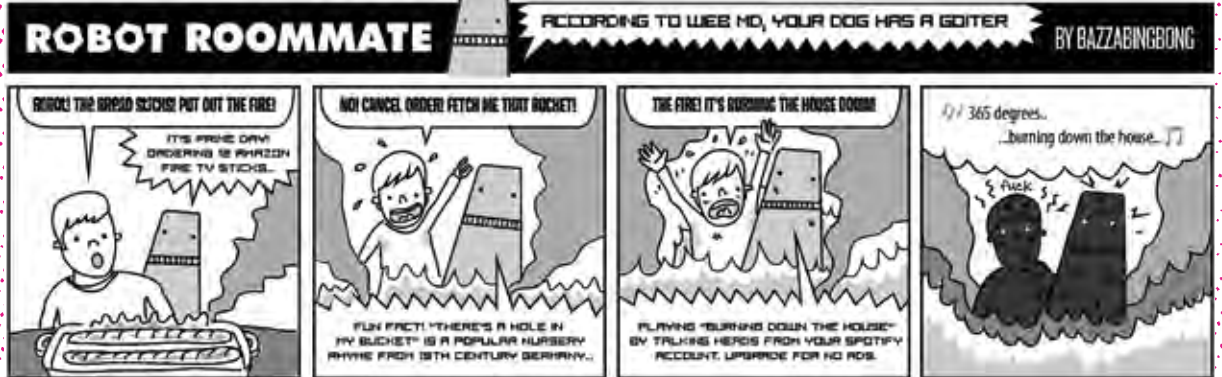




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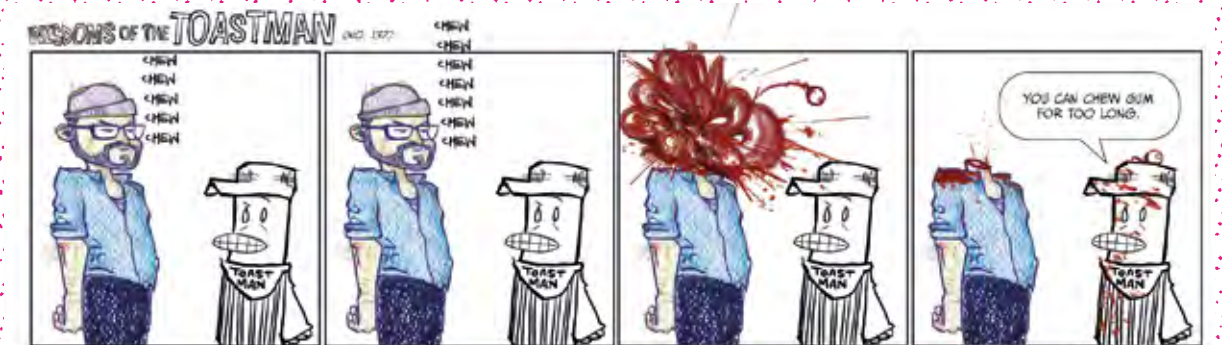
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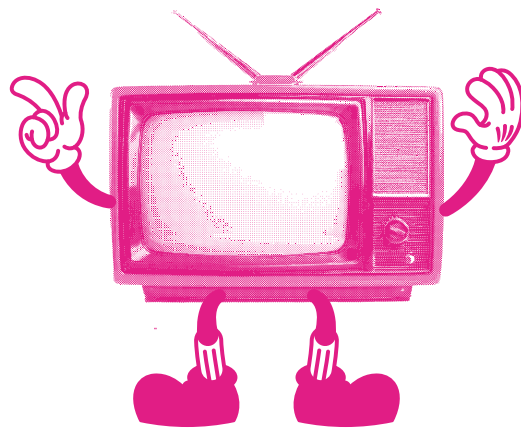
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